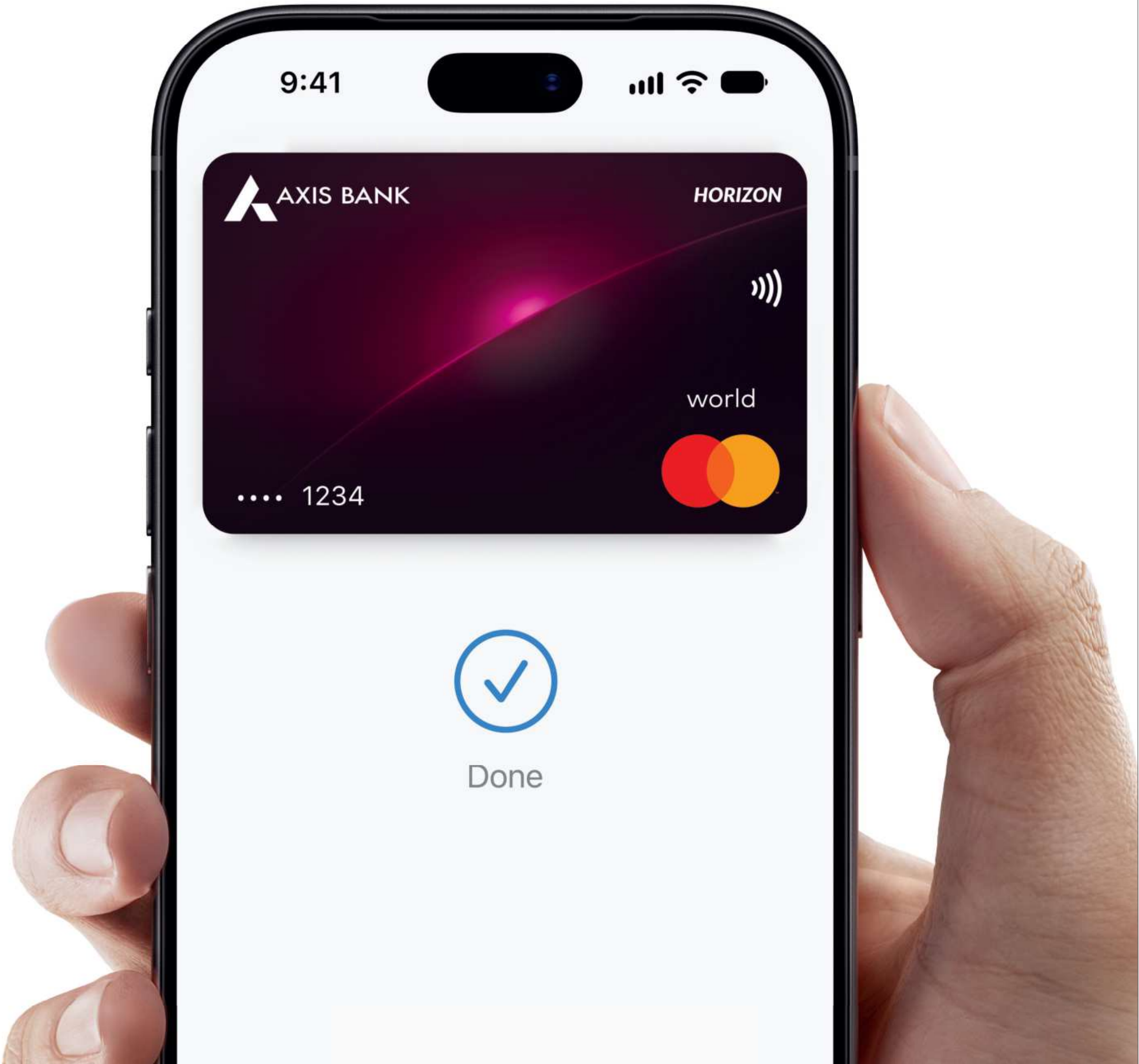




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‘Assault on lawyer’: Rohini bar to boycott work today

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Rohini Court Bar Association has called for a complete abstention from judicial work at the district court complex on Monday to protest against the alleged manhandling and physical assault of an advocate at a police station.

It also said that no police officer from any district would be allowed to enter the court premises during the day. In a notice dated October 3 and signed by Bar association president Rajiv Tehran and honorary secretary Pardeep Khatri, the association stated advocate Kamaldeep was allegedly assaulted on September 29.

Instead of taking action against the police personnel, a case was registered against Mr. Kamaldeep, and senior officers did not inform the association’s executive committee about the case despite the assurances given to it, the association alleged.

AAP steps up stir against CEC; bid to vitiate atmosphere: BJP

Oppn. party doubles down on demand for Gyanesh Kumar’s removal, demands FIR against police officer accused of sexual harassment by 3 women scribes; traffic restricted in parts of central Delhi

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Sunday intensified its agitation against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, seeking his removal, and demanded action against the police officer whom three women journalists have accused of sexual harassment.

Traffic movement in central Delhi was temporarily restricted as hundreds of personnel from Delhi Police, Central Armed Police Forces and the Rapid Action Force were deployed, along with buses and PCR vans, to prevent the protest march called by various organisations, civil society groups and student organisations, including AAP’s student wing – the Association of Students for Alternative Politics.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), meanwhile, accused AAP of trying to “vi-



Aam Aadmi Party workers marching towards India Gate in New Delhi on Sunday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

tiate Delhi’s political atmosphere” and disrupt law and order.

AAP staged protests outside the Parliament Street police station and later at India Gate, where at least 25 of its members were detained while trying to march towards the headquarters of the Election Commission.

The party’s Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj, joined by party colleagues and ASAP members, al-

leged “different standards of action” in cases involving ordinary citizens and those in positions of power. He demanded an FIR against the senior police officer accused of sexual harassment.

“For the past two days, there have been protests at Jantar Mantar, but not a single protester raised a hand against police personnel or engaged in any form of violence. Yet, look at the manner in which the

police treated elderly citizens, civil society members, MPs and MLAs. We tolerated all of that,” he said. However, Mr. Bharadwaj added that if an officer is found misbehaving with a woman journalist, “India will not tolerate it.”

Reacting to a video of Mr. Bharadwaj being detained, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal wrote on X: “This is absolutely shocking. [Prime Minister Narendra] Modi ji has left even Hitler behind.”

‘Communist ideology’

Delhi BJP spokesperson Praveen Shankar Kapoor said it was “extremely unfortunate” that a handful of people associated with “communist ideology” were trying to “vitate Delhi’s political atmosphere”.

He alleged that AAP and its “communist allies” had brought people from Punjab for the protests in the national capital.

(With inputs from PTI)

INDIA bloc to protest outside CEO’s office on Wednesday

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Congress on Sunday announced that constituent parties of the INDIA bloc in Delhi will stage a protest outside the office of Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Ashok Kumar at Kashmere Gate on Wednesday seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged flaws in the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The parties will also join a march to the Election Commission (EC) of India headquarters on Tuesday, as part of the national call by INDIA bloc MPs.

The announcement came after a meeting of the INDIA bloc’s Delhi constituent parties, which included 33 leaders from 19 political parties.

The Aam Aadmi Party has exited the INDIA bloc and has been organising separate protests on the same issue.

In a joint release, the INDIA bloc stated the protest



Police personnel trying to remove a protester stalling a bus carrying fellow demonstrators, in New Delhi on Sunday. REUTERS

would highlight what the parties described as the “failures of the Delhi CEO” in enrolling voters, particularly those from minority communities and those from poor backgrounds.

“The protest would also raise concerns over more than 47 lakh people being left out of the draft electoral roll under the SIR in Delhi, with another 33 lakh voters being served notices asking them to prove their eligibility,” the statement added.

Anil Bhardwaj, general secretary (organisation) of Delhi Congress, said the INDIA bloc demanded that the SIR process be immediately repealed and the

voter-list revision process be made transparent.

‘United struggle’

He said the protest on Wednesday would signal a “united struggle to protect the rights of Delhi voters, fair elections and the democratic system”.

On September 30, the INDIA bloc announced a graded agitation plan, which includes protest marches at district headquarters, public meetings, a march to the EC headquarters and a joint appeal to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant for expedited hearings in cases related to the SIR and alleged “malpractices”.

IIT-D scholar dies; abetment to suicide case filed

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi police on Sunday registered an FIR in connection with the death of an IIT Delhi PhD scholar, weeks after he was found unconscious and injured at his rented house in Munirka on August 18, the police said.

The case was booked under Section 108 (abetment to suicide) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita based on a complaint by a security officer at IIT Delhi and in accordance with Supreme Court guidelines.

According to the police, the door was locked from inside, and neighbours broke open the door be-

fore the police shifted him to the AIIMS Trauma Centre, where he remained under treatment until he succumbed to his injuries on Saturday, the police said. It clarified that the incident happened outside the institute campus.

According to police, neither the family nor witnesses have raised suspi-

cions or made allegations against anyone following the incident.

The police said the CCTV footage from outside the house confirmed that the scholar was alone inside the house. Further probe is under way.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Govt’s Saheli card roll-out marred by glitches

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Women passengers in the Capital now need Pink National Common Mobility Cards or ‘Saheli’ cards for free travel, following the Transport Department’s September 30 deadline for paper tickets. However, conductors continue to issue paper tickets to passengers without cards, many of whom are unaware of the rule or face persistent card glitches.

Launched in March, the Saheli card replaced the

flexible paper ticket system for women and transgender persons. According to the department, over 70 centres established at bus depots and Sub-Divisional Magistrate offices across the city have issued cards to over 19 lakh women so far.

Troubles persist

While a large number of women have the cards, many still request free paper tickets, claiming they were unaware of the change or faced issues getting them made. The Hindu travelled on different bus routes to as-

sess the usability of the smart cards.

“Regular travellers know the cards are mandatory. Those without them offer excuses like leaving them at home or not knowing about the rule... For now, we give them paper tickets,” said a conductor on route RL-77.

Conductors noted they have been informally instructed to allow passengers without cards until October 10 while raising awareness. Another reason conductors continue to issue paper tickets is the

“irregular functioning” of the cards. “It is hit-and-miss,” said Lata Kumari, a schoolteacher. “It works on some routes but fails most of the time.”

Citing privacy issues, college student Rachna Sharma questioned the idea behind the smart cards: “I don’t understand the purpose of a card if they still hand you a paper ticket. The ticket displays your name, which feels like a safety risk. I don’t have the card yet, but if those malfunction, will I be forced to pay?”

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, PWD DIVISION ASHOKNAGAR (M.P.)

TENDER NOTICE

NIT No-06/2026-27/EE/4861-4862

Ashoknagar, Date 30.09.2026

Online Tender for mentioned below are being invited. The Tender have been uploaded on the e-Procurement system of Public Works Department on the Portal www.mptenders.gov.in Tender details are as below:-

S. No	Tender No.	Nature of work	Name of work	Call No.	Cost of Project (PAC) (In lack)	1-EMD 2- Cost of Tender form
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	2026_PWD RB _538788_1	Strengthening Work	Construction of 3 Units X 4 Cells X 5 MX5 M Box Culvert in KM 2/8, Construction of 2 Units X 4 Cells X 5 MX5 M Box Culvert in KM 9/2 & Construction of 2 Units X 4 Cells X 5 MX5 M Box Culvert in Km 13/6 on Wajidpur to Panwadi Hat Road Under Sub Division Ashoknagar Division Ashoknagar (M.P)	1st Call	970.25	1- Rs 9,70,250/- 2- Rs. 20,000/-
2	2026_PWD RB _538789_1	Strengthening Work	Construction of Gundar Joint to Bayanga Ganihari Derkha Sihar Kurayla Road Length-11.50 Km under Sub Division Ashoknagar Division Ashoknagar (MP)	1st Call	743.80	1- Rs.743800/- 2- Rs. 20,000/-
3	2026_PWD RB _538790_1	Strengthening Work	Construction of Shadora Naisarai (MDR) to Gundar Bagulya Diyadhari Road Length 6.70 Km under Sub Division Ashoknagar Division Ashoknagar (MP)	1st Call	392.84	1- Rs. 3,92,840/- 2- Rs.15,000/-
4	2026_PWD RB _538791_1	PLAN Work	Construction of Mungaoli Malhargarh Road to Patthargarh Lenth-0.70 Km	1st Call	69.30	1- Rs 69,300/- 2- Rs.10,000/-
Total:-					2176.19	

The document can only be purchased online from the above website after making online payment. The last date & time for purchase of Document and online submission of bid is Dated 19.10.2026 up to (17:30). NIT will be opened on 21.10.2026 (10:00 am). Detailed NIT and other details can be viewed on the above mentioned portal. Amendments to NIT, if any, would be published on website only, and not in newspaper.

G19455/26

Executive Engineer
PWD Division Ashoknagar(MP)



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No. IADB/ENGG/PMC/ETND-EP-10/2087/2026-27 Date: 03.10.2026

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KIADB is inviting tenders under Quality Based Consultancy System (QCBS) as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 and Rules 2000 through electronic procurement from eligible Consulting Firms under two cover system for the following works :

Name of the Works: (1) Project Management Consultancy Services for the work of Formation of Industrial Layout including construction of Roads, Construction of RCC Side Drains, RCC Cross Drainage Works, Retaining wall & HDPE Dual Water supply pipeline in Sector-1 for Sub Layout in KGF Industrial Area, Bangaradagani Village, KGF Taluk, Kolar District. (2) Project Management Consultancy Services for the work of Formation of Industrial Layout including construction of Roads, Construction of RCC Side Drains, RCC Cross Drainage Works, Retaining Wall & HDPE Dual Water Supply pipe line in Sector-2 for Sub layout in KGF Industrial Area, Bangaradagani Village, KGF Taluk, Kolar District. (3) Project Management Consultancy Services for the work of Improvement to Industrial Layout including reconstruction and re-surfacing of 12m wide and 18m wide roads including flexible pavement, construction of RCC side drain, RCC cross drainage in Bommasandra Jigani Link Road Industrial Area, Anekal Taluk, Bengaluru Urban District. (4) Project Management Consultancy Services for the work of Improvement to Industrial Layout including Reconstruction and resurfacing of 12m & 18m wide roads including flexible pavement, construction of RCC Side Drains, RCC Cross Drainage in Bommasandra 1st, 2nd & 3rd Phase Industrial Area, Anekal Taluk, Bengaluru Urban District.

The last date and time of receipt of tender is : **22.10.2026 upto 4.00 pm.**

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Hold talks with MPSC aspirants: Pawar to govt.

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Nationalist Congress Party (SP) chief Sharad Pawar on Sunday urged the Maharashtra government to immediately hold talks with protesting Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) aspirants and address their concerns over exam transparency and administrative reforms.

Mr. Pawar said he would support the aspirants and raise their demands in the Assembly.

Timings DELHI			
MONDAY, OCT. 05			
RISE	06:16	SET	18:03
RISE	00:35	SET	14:47
TUESDAY, OCT. 06			
RISE	06:16	SET	18:02
RISE	01:43	SET	15:27
WEDNESDAY, OCT. 07			
RISE	06:17	SET	18:01
RISE	02:47	SET	16:01

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	36	24
Safdarjang	36	24
Palam	35	22

Delhi Palam Today
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INDIA bloc victory in U.P. poll more important than seat sharing, says SP chief

Akhilesh's remarks come amid war of words on division of seats between leaders of his party and the Congress; motivation should be to ensure democracy, quotas are not harmed by BJP, he says

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday said the victory of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc in the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly election was more important than the number of seats given to each alliance partner.

"The motivation should be that communalism never raises its head again and democracy, the Constitution, and reservations are not harmed by the divisive Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)," Mr. Yadav wrote in a post on X.

"When the purpose is clear, it goes hand in hand. If your eyes are on the destination, the journey becomes easy. The important thing is not how many seats are in the alliance or



Gearing up: Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav (centre) with senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi. FILE PHOTO

which seat is going to whom; the important thing is that we all have to ensure the alliance wins. Let us repeat again: it is not about the seat but victory. It will be the victory of the joint effort of all of us," he added.

The statement comes amid a war of words between leaders of the two parties over the number of seats the Congress would contest in the Assembly election. Uttar Pradesh has

a 403-member Assembly.

Tussle continues
U.P. Congress in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam on Sunday reacted strongly to SP Lok Sabha MP Shivpal Singh Patel's statement a day earlier that the Congress should not expect more than 50 seats.

"Then he [Mr. Patel] should refuse; he should clearly say that he does not want to form an alliance. At least the matter should

be fair. What was the need to make such a light statement?" Mr. Gautam said.

He said both parties would win the election and form the government together. "When have we talked about defeat? We too are talking about victory," Mr. Gautam said.

Earlier, former State Minister and senior SP leader I.P. Singh referred to the 2023 Madhya Pradesh Assembly election, when a delegation of senior party leaders had waited at the doorstep of then Congress Chief Minister Kamal Nath until the last day of ticket distribution.

"But the Congress did not give a single seat to the SP in Madhya Pradesh," Mr. Singh said.

"When needed, the Congress takes support from the SP and regional parties, but when it comes to sharing, the doors are closed," he added.

Farmers in Haryana block highway over 'procurement delay'

Press Trust of India
YAMUNANAGAR

A group of farmers on Sunday blocked a stretch of the Panchkula-Saharanpur highway at Aurangabad village in Haryana's Yamunanagar district, alleging delays in paddy procurement by the State government. They later lifted the blockade following talks with local authorities.

Bharatiya Kisan Union (BKU) national spokesperson Rakesh Tikait, who was present at the site, told reporters, "What else can a farmer do if the Haryana government does not procure his grain? First, the government said the procurement will start on September 25. Then it gave another date - September 29. The farmers are facing problems as their foodgrains are not being procured," Mr. Tikait said.

"These are the same farmers who surrounded Delhi for 13 months (during the protest against the now-repealed farm laws). They should not be harassed in the name of procurement," he added.

Mr. Tikait said the BKU



BKU national spokesperson Rakesh Tikait

would support any decision taken by Haryana's farmers.

Cong. takes stock
Meanwhile, Congress's Haryana in-charge Sanjay Dutt and the party's State unit president, Rao Narendra Singh, on Sunday visited the grain market in Karnal and took stock of paddy procurement arrangements.

Mr. Dutt said farmers across Haryana are reaching markets with their produce, but are struggling to sell their crops.

"In some places, procurement is being delayed, while in others, lifting arrangements have broken down and farmers are being made to wait for payments," he said.

Investigate embankment breaches: RJD MP to Bihar CM

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Amid floods in several districts of Bihar, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) MP from Buxar Sudhakar Singh on Sunday wrote to Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary seeking an independent inquiry into widespread flooding and embankment breaches across the State.

Mr. Singh also sought a review of expenditure on construction and maintenance and action against erring officials and engineers. He said the incidents were "deeply concerning". "Keeping the embankments strong amid heavy rains and rising river water levels are a crucial responsibility of officials. Therefore, an inquiry is needed into these incidents which can determine the extent to which substandard construction, inadequate maintenance and administrative negligence contributed to the breaches," the letter read.

Mr. Singh also said an inquiry should also be conducted on action taken in response to warnings from villagers or local representatives.

'Mad Sandhu' killing puts focus on vanishing social media posts, Punjab's queer history

Amarjot Kaur
CHANDIGARH

The busy commercial-cum-residential lane on Loharka Road in Amritsar now bears witness to the stains of violence towards vulnerable communities on Punjab's soil. LGBTQA+

influencer and make-up artist Mad Sandhu, officially named Madhusudan, was shot dead by unidentified bike-borne men on Saturday evening.

A day after the killing, news reports stated that posts on social media accounts claimed responsi-

bility for Sandhu's murder. Ironically, these posts are nowhere to be found now.

With speculations rife and police investigations under way, Sikh radical groups have also come under the radar following the news of a three-month-old audio-video clip allegedly

featuring a confrontation between Sandhu and Nihang jathedar Manpreet Singh Khalsa.

Amritsar Police Commissioner Harmanbir Singh Gill said, "We cannot verify the authenticity of these social media posts as they are posted from

abroad. We are viewing this case from multiple angles, the investigation is going in the right direction."

Sandhu's murder has triggered strong reactions, both online and offline, from Punjab's LGBTQA+ community as well as political leaders.

"It is probably because this is the first such crime against a person from the LGBTQA+ community in the State, even though they have been discriminated for a long time," said Manu, a member of Queering in Chandigarh, an LGBTQA+ collective formed in 2022.



Madhusudan, also known as Mad Sandhu, was shot dead on Saturday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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M N D N D E

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday announced that Bhadohi district has been renamed as Sant Ravidas Nagar Bhadohi. The Chief Minister was addressing a gathering in Bhadohi after he inaugurated and laid the foundation stones for 112 projects worth over ₹1,340 crore. "On the occasion of Guru Purnima, we had said that Bhadohi district, currently known for its carpet industry, would in the future be known by the name of Satguru Ravidas ji Maharaj, a medieval saint who united society through his spiritual devotion," Mr. Adityanath said.

Six Congress leaders accused of allegedly writing slogans with black paint on the gate and outer wall of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's residence in Agra were released from the Agra district jail on Sunday, a day after a local court granted them bail. The six leaders - Mukesh Dhanger, Anil Yadav, Rajesh Kumar, Manoj Gaur, Rajesh Gautam, and Pankaj Chaudhary - were arrested on September 29 in connection with the defacement incident in the Vijay Nagar area a day earlier. The court had granted them bail on Saturday after the police dropped the attempt to murder charge during the investigation. PTI

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

Chaos unfolded outside the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) here on Sunday during a protest by members of the Bangiya Hindu Jagaran Mancha as police prevented them from entering the campus.

The protest was held against the September 27 clash on the campus between students and an RSS-affiliated group.

Press Trust of India
AMARGARH (PUNJAB)

Shiramani Akali Dal (SAD) chief Sukhbir Singh Badal on Sunday appealed to Punjab voters to choose the right Chief Minister to take the State forward. He said if they wanted speedy development, coupled with new age agriculture and employment models, he was "most fit" for the post.

Addressing a 'Punjab Bachao' rally in Amargarh, Mr. Badal congratulated the party's new constituency in-charge Jassi Manvi. He al-

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya on Sunday questioned why there has been no decision on Bhartiya Janata Party's (BJP) MLA Raju Singh's membership despite being convicted in a celebratory firing case that led to the death of a woman.

Mr. Bhattacharya said in the case of former CPI(M) MLA Manoj Manzil, a different approach was



Mr. Bhattacharya sought an answer and raised ques-

tions about the intention of Bihar Legislative Assembly Speaker Prem Kumar.

Different standards
Singh, an MLA from Sahebganj in Bihar, was sentenced to four years of simple imprisonment by a trial court on July 4 for the death of Archana Gupta, who was shot during a New Year's Eve party at a farmhouse in Delhi's Fatehpur Beri area on December 31, 2018. "Why is the Speaker failing to make a decision on this matter?" Mr. Bhat-tacharya said while speak-

ing to reporters in Patna. “Manoj Manzil’s membership was revoked immediately after his conviction on February 12, 2024. Subsequently, a bye-election was held in the Agiaon (SC) Assembly constituency alongside the 2024 Lok Sabha election,” he said.

Mr. Bhattacharya asked why different standards are being applied in cases of conviction within the same Assembly.

The Ara MP/MLA court on February 13, 2024 had sentenced Manzil to life imprisonment in the case.

Satyasundar Barik

For 35 years, Balunkeswar Paikray has travelled hundreds of kilometres and knocked on the doors of every authority he could think of. He even reached out to the Prime Minister and touched the feet of local government officials in the hope that someone would listen. The 55-year-old visually impaired man from Odisha's Khordha district says, "I am not asking for charity. I am fighting for a rightful share in my ancestral property."

Paikray says his share among his three siblings would amount to 40,000 square feet of paternal property in Khordha's Kadab village. "Now, I live in less than 300 square feet," he says of his room, bathroom, and backyard.

His long struggle has given him a painful insight into how the world treats those who cannot see, walk, or behave in what is considered regular. His battle has revealed how a disability can deepen a person's vulnerability, strip away social standing and, in the maze of bureaucracy and family rows, reduce an individual to almost a non-entity.

In August, the Odisha government formulated a comprehensive set of guidelines to safeguard the property and inheritance

rights of persons with disabilities (PwDs) under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016. Paikrav and lakhs of others saw hope. The move was also welcomed by those working in the disability sector, who see it as a significant step towards protecting PwDs from discrimination in matters of property, including ancestral, inherited, and self-acquired.

The three-page guidelines suggested that the Revenue and Disaster Management Department examine the feasibility of issuing comprehensive guidelines and instructions to all revenue authorities to safeguard the land and property rights of PwDs.

Key proposals

One of the key proposals is to maintain a register of complaints relating to the property rights of PwDs at the tehsil and Sub-Collector levels, with periodic monitoring by the District Collector. Activists say while revenue laws provide safeguards for Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe communities - including prior permission for transfer of land or property to persons from the general category - PwDs remain more vulnerable and require similar protection.

In August, the Odisha government's Suresh Kumar Vashishth wrote to Arabinda Kumar Padhee to issue comprehensive guidelines that would protect

The Odisha govt. has framed guidelines to safeguard the property rights of persons with disabilities. Activists say the rules are needed for both inherited and self-acquired property, and can help improve lives



Balunkeswar Paikray, a visually impaired resident of Kadab village in Khordha district, has spent three decades fighting to reclaim his share of inherited property. He has approached several authorities, including the Prime Minister, but says his efforts are yet to yield a resolution. BISWARANJAN ROUT

all PwDs' rights over inherited and self-acquired property. Vashishth is Principal Secretary to the Department of Social Security and Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities; Padhee is Additional Chief Secretary, Revenue and Disaster Management Department, under which property is registered.

The guidelines were formulated based on the 2016 Act, particularly Sections 12, 13, 84, and 85. These cast an obligation upon the government to ensure pro-

tection of the rights, property, legal capacity, and the interests of PwDs and to prevent all forms of abuse, violence, exploitation, and discrimination. Vashishth suggested immediate inquiry upon receipt of complaints relating to illegal occupation, encroachment, cultivation, mutation, or alienation of lands belonging to PwDs and strict monitoring of these properties. He suggested capacity building and sensitisation of revenue officers to the rights of

persons with disabilities under the Act, and the need for adopting disability-sensitive procedures.

Bratati Harichandan, State Commissioner for Persons with Disabilities, says this is an inter-departmental effort. "We have requested the Panchayati Raj Department to sensitize officials at the grassroots so that persons with disabilities are accommodated under government housing schemes and assured of a roof over their heads, particularly when they are

forced out of their own homes," Harichandan says.

The struggle

Milan Kumar Das, 45, his brother Chandan, and sister Mamata, from Bhadrak district, all of whom have 100% locomotor disabilities, are easy targets for those determined to usurp legally inherited property.

Confined to a cramped 100-square-foot room, the siblings and their 80-year-old mother depend on each other for survival. Together, they receive about ₹14,000 a month in disability and other pensions, while subsidised rice keeps hunger at bay. What weighs on them most is not poverty, but the loss of property that they say should have been theirs.

"Our father was an employee of Indian Oil Corporation. He had purchased land and built a house here [in Nadigaon village in Bhadrak district]. After his death, we were driven out by other members of the joint family. Only after police intervention, were we given a tiny room as shelter," Milan says, adding that for nearly 10 years, he and his siblings appealed to the Bhadrak district administration and police seeking justice.

In Jajpur district, Prakash Mohapatra, 48, who is visually impaired, worries about his future. "Now I live with my mother and brother in the village," he says, fearing the situation

will change with time. “My repeated applications for a house under the Prime Minister Awas Yojana have not led anywhere, the application is stuck in some government office.”

Manjulata Panda, 49, Odisha’s first visually impaired woman to earn a PhD and now a lecturer in a college in Sambalpur district, is fighting to get the family property registered in her and her brother’s names. He too is visually impaired and is a teacher in a government primary school. “Since both of us have good jobs, we don’t struggle for food or survival. But our ancestral properties are entangled in a procedural mess. We are not able to record it in our name,” Panda says. In Panda’s case, no one else has claimed the land, but she says there are “procedural hurdles” that the government must help with.

The State government’s move came after Dr. Arabindia Mohanty, a paediatrician by profession and an activist on disability for more than three decades, highlighted the plight of people with physical and intellectual disabilities.

In 2025, he wrote to the State Commission for Persons with Disabilities to take up the issue with the government, insisting on the need for such guidelines. “I have come across numerous cases of discrimination against intellectually challenged and

physically challenged persons. Invariably, they don't get the rightful share of their ancestral property," says Mohanty.

Redressal of grievances

Shruti Mohapatra, 63, a disability rights activist, who is herself a person with orthopaedic disability, says those with intellectual disabilities are among the most vulnerable when it comes to the transfer and protection of property rights. "To some extent, those with visual, hearing, and orthopaedic disabilities can raise their voices against discrimination or injustice. But persons with intellectual disabilities are largely dependent on their parents or trusted legal guardians," she says.

Mohapatra also points to the lack of disability-friendly facilities in the justice system. "While society often ignores and disowns persons with intellectual disabilities, the government has also failed to ensure adequate employment opportunities for them," says Kartik Chandrapandab, secretary of Rourkela-based voluntary organisation Shradha Foundation, which works in the disability sector.

Meanwhile, Paikray hopes the State government's guidelines will finally help him claim his share of property.

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BJP agent tried to get 7,561 electors deleted in Ballari

Karnataka Police file FIR against booth-level agent who repeatedly tried to submit Form 7 in bulk to remove voters' names; complainant says most of the voters belonged to a minority community

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

Claiming that more than 7,500 electors were either “absent or had shifted”, a BJP-affiliated booth-level agent (BLA) in Karnataka tried to first submit Form 7 applications (seeking deletion of names) and, after his claims were not accepted by the election authorities, again sought “revision” of their names by submitting objections, even though these voters figured in the draft electoral roll of the Ballari City Assembly constituency.

In this regard, a first information report (FIR) was registered at the Brucepet police station on October 1 against the agent, T. Srinivas Mothkur, who is also the Opposition leader of the Ballari City Corporation.

The FIR books the accused under Section 353 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, for “statements conducting to public mischief”. Mr. Mothkur, BJP’s BLA-1, had sought deletion of names of 7,561 electors.

Sixth in State

The FIR, filed on a complaint from a Congress BLA, is the sixth one registered in Karnataka regarding misuse of Form 7.

Of the previous five FIRs, two filed in Belagavi and one in Mysuru names BJP members as accused.

The FIR followed a se-



Cracking the whip: Of the previous five FIRs filed in Karnataka for misuse of Form 7 applications, three names BJP members as accused. FILE PHOTO

ries of attempts by Mr. Mothkur to submit the objections. On September 21, he wrote to the Ballari City Corporation saying that while he was trying to submit Form 7 applications through the booth-level officers (BLOs) concerned, many of them had refused to accept them. Since only a few BLOs considered his applications, he took the remaining ones directly to the electoral registration officer (ERO).

In their response the same day, election authorities from the Ballari City Corporation said Mr. Mothkur’s claims that the voters were already registered elsewhere, absent or had permanently shifted “were not supported” by documents or other information. The ERO said that while the BLAs were allowed to submit applica-

tions in bulk, they could not submit more than 10 applications to a BLO at a time or in a day. If a BLA submitted more than 30 applications during the claims and objections period, the ERO or AERO had to personally cross-verify them. The BLA was also required to submit a list of the applications along with a declaration that he had personally verified the particulars and was satisfied that they were correct, the ERO’s letter said.

Following this response, Mr. Mothkur made another attempt the following day.

On September 22, he wrote to the election authorities saying that he was ready to submit objections against 7,561 voters in the draft electoral roll of the Ballari City Assembly constituency. He enclosed the list of names and sought

necessary action “at the earliest”.

The election authorities again rejected his claim, arguing that it was not possible to verify the voters’ registration merely on the basis of the complaint.

‘Names re-verified’

Following Mr. Mothkur’s repeated attempts to seek deletion of the names, Congress BLA Goutham S. filed a complaint with the police. He said that at some polling stations, election officials had re-verified the names based on Mr. Mothkur’s objections. He also alleged that the majority of the voters belonged to a minority community.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Mothkur said that he had not sought deletion of the names but had only provided the details to the ERO to verify.

Fake death records used for deletion; inquiry ordered

The Hindu Bureau
BELAGAVI

K. Anand, Deputy Commissioner and District Election Officer (DEO), Vijayapura, Karnataka, has ordered an inquiry into allegations that some objectors in the city had created false death certificates to seek the deletion of names of some voters under the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

This follows a memorandum submitted by at least eight people who presented themselves before the district electoral office in Vijayapura on Saturday. They said they had been declared dead in Form 7 applications by some objectors in the city, who had used fudged documents.

Allama Bagwan, a government school teacher, was shocked to find that someone had submitted a third-party objection under Form 7, saying she had died. The booth-level officer (BLO) informed her that an application had been submitted stating she was no more. “The BLO visited my house and collected details from me. He assured me my name would not be deleted. I was shocked to find out that someone had managed to procure a death certificate saying I was dead,” she told officials.

‘Yatnal targeting voters’ Similarly, Abdul Razak Bagwan, Malanbi Jamadar, Mumtaj Mulla and four others were shocked when they learned that docu-

Attempts were made to remove about 1,046 Muslim voters in Bijapur, alleges Congress leader

ments showing them as dead had been submitted to delete their names.

This was flagged by Congress leaders who went from door to door to find out if there were mismatches between the existing rolls and the current SIR exercise. They found some followers of Basangouda Patil Yatnal, an expelled BJP MLA, had filed objections to inclusion of these names, after affixing fake death certificates of at least eight people along with Form 7 applications seeking their deletion.

“They also found that the certificates were issued by competent authorities, but lacked details. In several cases, the names of parents or spouses did not match with those of the victims. This is a clear case of Mr. Yatnal and other Hindutva leaders trying to target Muslim voters. We demand a comprehensive investigation and legal action against those responsible for this,” Abdul Hamid Mushrif, a Congress leader, told reporters on Sunday.

He claimed that attempts were made to remove about 1,046 voters belonging to the minority community, across 198 polling stations of the Bijapur city constituency, by falsely claiming that they were dead.

Former security camp in Bastar gets new life as tribal boys’ hostel

Shubhomov Sikdar
RAIPUR

Not long ago, there was a security camp in Bhatpal, a remote area of Chhattisgarh’s Narayanpur district in the Bastar region. As the security situation improved, the campus, which housed security personnel deployed in the insurgency-hit region for over 15 years, has found a new identity as a residential facility for over 150 tribal schoolboys.

Narayanpur Collector Namrata Jain said this was the first such initiative in the Bastar division. The former security camp has been converted for educational and hostel purposes, “marking a shift from security-oriented infrastructure to facilities focused on education and the future of children in the region”.

Serving as a residential facility since August 11 this year, months after the Centre declared India free from Maoism, the campus has two sections – one each serving as a hostel for pre-matric Scheduled Tribe boys and post-matric Scheduled Tribe boys.

According to a statement by the district administration, the pre-matric hostel, catering to students from Classes 6 to 10, has a sanctioned capacity of 100 students and currently accommodates 114 students.

The post-matric Scheduled Tribe Boys’ Hostel, for students of Classes 11 and 12, has a sanctioned capacity of 50 students and currently accommodates 39 students. The hos-



This is Bastar’s first former security camp converted into a hostel facility, the Collector said. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

tel is meeting the residential requirements of students associated with Education City, Kutul.

Komendra, a Class 12 student from Rajbada, located around 22 km away, said the opening of the post-matric hostel provided him relief. Earlier, he had to stay outside the school premises and incur additional expenditure on accommodation. The hostel has now provided him with a safe and affordable option close to his school.

“The aim was to address one of the key challenges faced by children from distant and difficult-to-access areas – access to safe accommodation close to school,” Ms. Jain said.

“The transformation reflects the changing development priorities in areas that have historically faced challenges related to security, connectivity, and access to basic services. As the region moves towards a new phase of development, existing infrastructure is being utilised to strengthen education, social development, and opportunities for local communities,” she added.

Six lakh more houses to be built in A.P., says Union Minister

G.V.R. Subba Rao
VIJAYAWADA

Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Sunday said the Centre would sanction another six lakh houses for Andhra Pradesh, in addition to the three lakh houses currently being taken up under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) 2.0.

Addressing a public meeting at Burripalem in Tenali mandal after laying the foundation for the construction of three lakh houses in the State, Mr. Chouhan said another three lakh houses would be sanctioned by the time the ongoing construction was completed and an additional three lakh houses would also be allocated to the State.

Praise for State govt.

Praising Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, Mr. Chouhan said Andhra Pradesh was emerging as a leading State in the country under his leadership.

He said the Centre was providing ₹6,000 a year to farmers and the State government was adding another ₹14,000 under the Annadata Sukhibhava scheme, taking the total annual assistance to ₹20,000.

Addressing the gathering at Tenali, Mr. Naidu said the Centre had initially sanctioned 75,000 houses under the regular quota, but three lakh houses were sanctioned following a special request made by the State. He said the State government aims to achieve 100% coverage under the housing initiative by 2029.

Rooting for rice



Wobbly weather: Workers planting paddy saplings in a field at Puzhakkal in Thrissur on Sunday, as moderate rainfall over the past three days brought some relief to farmers. The southwest monsoon has officially ended, with Kerala recording a 28% rainfall deficit, receiving 1,446.5 mm against the normal 2,018.6 mm. Large parts of the State are facing drought-like conditions. K.K. MUSTAFAH

R. Sreelekha drops resignation plan, to continue as councillor

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A day after R. Sreelekha, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) councillor of the Thiruvananthapuram Corporation in Kerala expressed her desire to quit as Sasthamangalam ward councillor, she appears to have done a U-turn with BJP leaders, including State general secretary S. Suresh and Mayor V.V. Rajesh, saying she would continue in her position.

Ms. Sreelekha reportedly mentioned in her ward’s WhatsApp group on Saturday that she had informed the Mayor through a letter on September 30 about resigning as a councillor for personal reasons.



R. Sreelekha

The Mayor had tried to downplay the development, saying Ms. Sreelekha had only handed over a letter expressing personal inconveniences. He did not confirm if the letter communicated her resignation.

On Sunday, Mr. Suresh posted a photograph of him visiting her in a hospi-

tal. He said Ms. Sreelekha had merely expressed her concern to close associates about whether she would be able to effectively discharge her duties as a people’s representative, which later became fodder for media speculation. Her post in the WhatsApp group was also reportedly deleted on Sunday.

CPI(M) leader V. Sivankutty told presspersons on Sunday the “resignation drama” needed to be seen only as a threat from Ms. Sreelekha to the BJP to gain new positions.

Ms. Sreelekha, a former Director-General of Police, had earlier made clear her displeasure at being overlooked for the Thiruvananthapuram Mayor post.

Activists worry coal mine near Ramappa Temple may harm heritage site and lake

P. Laxma Reddy
HYDERABAD

Heritage activists, including the Kakatiya Heritage Trust (KHT), are demanding the withdrawal of the proposed PVNR opencast coal mine at Venkatapur in Mulugu district of Telangana, contending that the project could pose a long-term threat to the UNESCO-inscribed Kakatiya Rudreshwara Temple, popularly known as Ramappa Temple, and the adjacent Ramappa Lake.

To mount pressure on the State government, they are planning to mobilise people from 15 villages and organise mass protests after the Dasara festival, against the proposed mine.



Old glory: UNESCO-inscribed Rudreshwara Temple, aka Ramappa Temple, was built by the Kakatiyas in the 13th century. NAGARA GOPAL

As part of the campaign, a delegation met Union Coal and Mines Minister G. Kishan Reddy in Hyderabad on Saturday and urged him to intervene and stop the proposed project. They said the Singareni Collieries Company Ltd. (SCCL)

was reportedly gearing up to take up the project despite concerns raised by conservationists.

Quoting technical observations, former Professor of NIT-Warangal M. Pandu Ranga Rao said the proposed mine would be lo-

cated about 5 km downstream of the lake and temple and involve excavation to a depth of about 300 metres. He said that a Geological Survey of India report contended that the water level in the lake could influence groundwater movement through geological lineaments and faults towards the proposed mine.

Mr. Rao further pointed to the sand-box foundation of the nearly 800-year-old Ramappa Temple and said interconnected lineaments passing through the lake and temple area could potentially affect the foundation through piping. “The temple is already showing signs of distress,” the KHT representative added.



Two or three?

Students must be free to choose a third language not tested in a Board exam

The Supreme Court, through its frequent interventions, is pointing to the various aspects of the three-language policy that the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) does not seem to have thought through. Regardless of its eventual judgment, the Court’s intent at this stage seems to be to point to the pitfalls of the policy and at least soften the rough edges. In its latest ruling, the Court has said that current Class 6 students should be given the same relief as students in Classes 7, 8 and 9, whose final Class 10 examination will only be an internal assessment, not a Board examination. The Court is seeking to lessen the load on the students, at least until schools are fully prepared. It had earlier asked if the policy could start from 2027, not 2026. The CBSE has stubbornly resisted compromise at various stages in the hearing. Earlier, the Court had intervened to point out that suddenly learning a new language in Class 9 would be too disruptive if the students had not studied a second “Indian” language until Class 8. The Court had also mooted careful consideration of treating English as indigenous, putting its categorisation as a foreign language under question.

English is a de facto Indian language. It has been in use in India for at least 300 years and is the leading language of education, courts, and professions widely practised by Indians; it also serves as the preferred link language for many. English knowledge has consistently given Indians an edge in employment in global industries such as the IT sector. Indians will want English to remain one of their unique selling points as the government looks to jobs in global industries as a pathway to prosperity. The National Education Policy 2020, though advocating for two Indian languages, also mentions the importance of learning foreign languages to facilitate the global mobility of Indians seeking employment. *The Hindu’s* reportage has shown that since English is the language of instruction in other subjects, it will become the only so-called foreign language students will take in CBSE schools. Many schools will stick to Sanskrit as the second Indian language all the way up to Class 10 while Hindi would be the first. Some schools, especially in the southern States, will continue with the regional language such as Tamil or Kannada as the other Indian language. The practical consequence of the current policy is removing Spanish, French and other foreign languages from schools. But any purported intent of promoting cross-regional language learning may just not be served though the Court has found merit in learning more Indian languages as a way of strengthening the federal structure. A strenuous learning of an additional Indian language serves little practical purpose though it may cater to the atavistic impulses of some. The two-language policy – English and mother tongue – would be best for India. Students can be tested on a third language of their choice through internal assessment, not through a Board examination.

Outbound force

The United States is leaving Iraq in weariness, if not defeat

The United States invaded Iraq in March 2003, saying that Saddam Hussein’s regime possessed weapons of mass destruction (WMD) and harboured terrorist groups. In 2011, then U.S. President Barack Obama announced America’s withdrawal, but its troops returned when the Islamic State captured huge swathes of territory in Iraq and Syria. On September 30, 2026, more than 23 years after the invasion, U.S. troops finally left Iraq, in the midst of another American war in the region. The war on Iraq has been one of the gravest strategic and humanitarian disasters of the 21st century. The WMD claim turned out to be false, if not an outright lie, while al-Qaeda built one of its most violent branches in post-war Iraq. The destruction of Saddam’s Ba’athist state and the abrupt rise of Shia parties widened social cleavages, triggering a deadly civil war, killing hundreds of thousands of Iraqis. The disastrous consequences of George W. Bush’s war did not end there. Al-Qaeda in Iraq transformed into the Islamic State by 2014 and spread terror across the region and beyond. The Popular Mobilisation Forces (PMFs), or Hashad al-Shabi, an umbrella of Iran-backed Shia militias, have since emerged as a state within the state.

Saddam’s Iraq, despite its hostile relations with Gulf monarchies, was a buffer between the Arab Gulf countries and Iran. When Saddam’s regime was toppled, Iran extended its influence across Iraq through Shia parties and militias. It is an irony that the U.S. is leaving Iraq at a time when it is trying to defeat Iran in a major regional war. But beneath the irony lies everything that went wrong with America’s regime-change wars, which destabilised parts of West Asia, gave rise to militias and jihadists and exposed the limits of American power in the region. When the U.S. and Israel began bombing Iraq on February 28, Hashad joined the war. Since then, Iran and its allies have carried out at least 600 attacks on U.S. military and diplomatic facilities in Iraq, a stark reminder to Washington that maintaining troops there had become unsustainable. If in Afghanistan the U.S. exited after 20 years of war leaving the country in the hands of the same Taliban that it had toppled in 2001, in Iraq, America is leaving behind a war-ravaged country in the hands of a weak government and powerful militias backed by a resurgent Iran. Iran and its allies have vowed to push the U.S. out of West Asia. They may not have the wherewithal to achieve that goal, but they have managed to drive the U.S. out of Iraq.

Never before has the Election Commission of India (ECI) been subjected to such public opprobrium as it is witnessing today. This constitutional body has always enjoyed the admiration of people both within and outside the country. Indeed, the reputation of India’s ECI has been global, because of its competence, impartiality and unwavering commitment to democratic norms. But today, its reputation is in the mud because of its actions in recent times, which smack of illegality, partisanship and worse. The manner in which it has carried out the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in various States shows an utter disregard for the law and a disdain for procedural correctness and constitutional propriety.

Electoral fears

The debate in the Constituent Assembly on the Election Commission (Draft Article 289) throws light on the thinking of its members about the functioning of this constitutional body. There was, in fact, unanimity among the members, including the Chairman of the Drafting Committee, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, that the ECI should be outside the control of the executive. Dr. Ambedkar was quite emphatic on this point. He said, “So far as the fundamental question is concerned that the election machinery should be outside the control of the executive government there has been no dispute.”

The members were conscious of the danger of an election commission being under the control of the government, which would undermine the integrity of the election. In fact, the proposal in the Draft Constitution was for a decentralised election machinery under which each province would have a chief election commissioner who would oversee the preparation of electoral rolls and the conduct of elections to the State legislatures. Elections to Parliament, as well as to the offices of the President and the Vice-President of India, would be conducted by a chief election commissioner at the Centre.

This proposal was rejected by Dr. Ambedkar himself, who moved an entirely different Article proposing to centralise the election machinery. The reason for rejecting the proposal and deciding to centralise the election machinery was that there had been instances in the provinces of large-scale deletion of voters regarded as opponents of the ruling party by the Chief Election Commissioners (CEC) of the States. These Commissioners were mostly political nominees of the Chief Ministers.

A new Article was therefore introduced, providing for a central Election Commission consisting of the CEC and other Election Commissioners (EC), with the responsibility of preparing electoral rolls and conducting elections to Parliament, State legislatures and the offices of the President and the Vice-President. It is an irony that, almost 80 years later, the same



P.D.T. Achary

Former Secretary General, Lok Sabha

The Election Commission of India’s conduct raises serious questions about legality, accountability and constitutional propriety

The ECI’s constitutional mandate is under strain

complaints against the CEC – of large-scale deletion of voters from electoral rolls without strict adherence to the law – have come up. The greater irony is that the ECs themselves have voiced complaints about the “illegal and unconstitutional” acts of the CEC.

It is interesting to note that senior members of the Constituent Assembly, such as Shibban Lal Saxena, had expressed the fear that a party in power in the future might appoint a staunch party loyalist as the CEC, who could manipulate the election machinery in favour of the ruling party. To avoid this, his suggestion was that any person appointed by the President should have to be approved by Parliament by a two-thirds majority, along the lines of the United States Senate’s confirmation of senior-level appointments.

The point is that the Constitution-makers could foresee the danger of a CEC acting in the interests of the ruling party and thereby subverting the entire constitutional scheme governing elections. It now appears that their fears were not unfounded.

An uncertain legal foundation

The SIR that has stirred up the present controversy is, in fact, not backed by any clear legal provision. Section 21 of the Representation of the People (RP) Act, 1950, provides for the preparation and revision of electoral rolls. It states: “The electoral roll for each constituency shall be prepared in the prescribed manner by reference to the qualifying date and shall come into force immediately upon its final publication in accordance with the rules made under this Act” [Section 21(1)].

“The said electoral roll shall ... be revised in the prescribed manner by reference to the qualifying date – (a) before each general election to the House of the People or to the Legislative Assembly of a State; (b) before each by election; and (c) shall be revised in any year in the prescribed manner by reference to the qualifying date if such revision has been directed by the Election Commission” [Section 21(2)]. Under Rule 25 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, a revision under Section 21(2) may be either intensive or summary, or partly intensive and partly summary.

There is yet another category of revision in Section 21(3), which says: “Notwithstanding anything contained in sub-section (2), the Election Commission may at any time, for reasons to be recorded, direct a special revision of the electoral roll for any constituency or part of a constituency in such manner as it may think fit.” The words “any constituency or a part of a constituency” make it abundantly clear that this special revision is meant to be done only in a limited number of constituencies where special circumstances exist. Thus, intensive revision and special revision are two different types of revision under different circumstances. The above

provisions make it clear that there is no mention in the law of a special intensive revision. How, then, could the ECI conduct a revision that is not provided for in law? Article 324 does not empower the ECI to do things against the law.

Under this Article, the ECI can exercise powers in respect of matters that are not covered by statute. Otherwise it is bound to act in accordance with the law

The cost of unilateralism

According to media reports, 13 crore Indian voters have already been removed from the electoral rolls across the country as a result of the SIR operations. Perhaps this is the biggest disenfranchisement exercise ever undertaken in any democratic country in the world. This exercise, needless to say, violates Article 326, which provides for universal adult suffrage and the right of eligible citizens to be registered as voters, subject to disqualification under law. The scheme of Article 326 is to include eligible voters, not to exclude them. But the objective of the SIR seems to be to exclude the maximum possible number of voters from the electoral rolls.

This huge mess has been created by the now obvious unilateralism that prevails in decision-making within the ECI. The appalling state of affairs in the domain of decision-making has been brought to light by the two ECs; according to them, they were not kept in the loop when crucial decisions were taken by the CEC.

The ECI is a constitutional body, and the procedure for decision-making is well laid in the law. A decision taken unilaterally by the CEC is not a valid decision, and all actions that follow from it have no legal validity. This creates a real constitutional crisis.

Opposition parties are preparing to move an impeachment motion against the CEC for serious misconduct. The CEC can be impeached in the same manner and on the same grounds as a judge of the Supreme Court of India. For the CEC to be removed, however, misbehaviour must be proved. The law also empowers the presiding officers of the two Houses of Parliament to disallow an impeachment motion at the threshold.

This provision could frustrate any attempt by Opposition Members of Parliament to initiate proceedings against either a judge or the CEC. Further, Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, further fortifies the CEC and other ECs by providing lifelong immunity from any civil or criminal liability. It may be noted that even the President of India does not enjoy such lifelong immunity. Such is the level of protection provided to the CEC and the other ECs. It is no wonder, therefore, that the Constitution, the law and citizens appear to have become helpless before an omnipotent ECI.

Colby’s mid-term report card, what it means for India

Elbridge A. Colby, the United States Under Secretary of War for Policy, has delivered a mid-term assessment of the Donald Trump administration’s defence strategy a month before the mid-term elections in the United States. His recent update on the 2026 National Defense Strategy shows how Washington is converting the administration’s priorities into policy.

The strategy focuses on four main goals: defending the U.S. homeland, deterring China, gaining more support from allies and partners, and rebuilding the U.S. defence industry. These priorities indicate clearly how Washington plans to manage its relationships. The U.S. wants its partners to be stronger, contribute more, and assume greater shares of the costs for regional security. India should consider this background when looking at the new American approach.

A different bargain with partners

For many years, the U.S. supplied much of the military strength behind its alliances and partnerships. Colby’s approach now demands that partners take more responsibility for security in their own regions. Europe is being urged to lead on its own defence. South Korea is expected to do more on the Korean Peninsula. Japan and Australia are also being asked to play a bigger role in the Indo-Pacific.

This new model combines American strategic leadership with stronger regional partners. The U.S. keeps its advanced capabilities, strategic coordination, and extended deterrence, while partners are expected to provide more troops, infrastructure, funding, and industrial support.

China is still the main strategic concern. The National Defense Strategy aims to stop China from dominating the Indo-Pacific by focusing on deterrence, especially along the First Island Chain. Meanwhile, the Trump administration is



Anil Raman

Retired Brigadier and a research fellow at the Takshashila Institution

The evolving defence strategy of the United States offers India an opportunity to build leverage

also negotiating with Beijing on trade and other matters. So, military competition and economic talks are happening simultaneously.

This has important implications for India. India’s value to Washington is substantially based on China and the Indo-Pacific, but the U.S.-China relationship can shift between competition and cooperation. So, Indian and American interests will often overlap but will not always align.

Russia is another factor into this new approach. The U.S. wants to lower its costs in the Ukraine War and expects Europe to take more responsibility for its own security. At the same time, the U.S. still wants to limit Russian military power and influence. For India, this connects directly to its defence ties with Russia, its energy needs, and its desire for strategic autonomy.

Europe shows this trend most clearly. Washington is urging European countries to build up their own defence capabilities. For India, the lesson is that strong regional partners are becoming more important in U.S. strategy.

What this means for India

India has a unique place in this new system. Its location, military potential, position in the Indian Ocean, technology goals, and role in the Indo-Pacific make it important to Washington. These interests have stayed mostly the same across different U.S. administrations.

The main change is in the contributions to the relationship. Washington now expects India to help keep the regional balance, work more closely on defence, join technology and supply-chain projects, and build up its military strength.

India also has good reasons to aim for these goals. It is building partnerships with France, Europe, Japan, Australia, the Gulf, and others, while keeping important ties with Russia and

other countries. These connections give India more capabilities and strategic choices.

This leads to a key question for the next stage of India-U.S. relations. The U.S. wants India to be stronger and do more for the Indo-Pacific balance. India wants to build its strength, partly to have more freedom to act on its own. Gaining leverage will therefore become increasingly important. A country’s importance to Washington does not automatically determine the terms on which Washington negotiates with it. Leverage does. Economic scale, military capability, technology, market access and the ability to offer or withhold strategically important capabilities all contribute to bargaining power.

The China example

China is a useful example. Its economic and technological strength gives Beijing the tools to influence the U.S.’s decisions. As India’s capabilities and economy grow, it will also have more influence in its relationship with Washington, but gaining that leverage will take time.

Colby’s mid-term report shows that the U.S. is putting more value on capable partners, regional responsibility, and shared contributions. For India, this is a big opportunity. A stronger India is more valuable to the U.S. and better able to look after its own interests.

New Delhi’s strategic task is to build that capability while keeping the freedom to use it. This means India needs to work more closely with Washington, but also keep building its own defence industry, technology sector, and partnerships. The next phase of India-U.S. relations will be shaped less by whether the two countries are strategic partners and more by the terms on which two increasingly capable powers cooperate.

biographical drama *Mayuri* were genre-defying masterpieces. It is no wonder that he was lovingly called the “celluloid scientist”. His classics will continue to inspire future generations.

Kshirasagara Balaji Rao, Hyderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Stronger sporting system

India’s campaign at the Aichi-Nagoya 2026 Asian Games has concluded with 21 gold, 27 silver and 37 bronze medals. Despite finishing below its 2023 tally, the country witnessed the emergence of several new champions. India also performed exceptionally well in team events. India, however, needs a comprehensive sporting

system that identifies talent at an early age, nurtures athletes through scientific training, provides quality coaching and gives them adequate international exposure.

John Deepak, Avinissery, Thrissur, Kerala

India has proved its supremacy in both the men’s and women’s sections in popular sports

such as hockey, cricket and kabaddi at the Asian Games. The nation has also excelled in athletics, archery, boxing, wrestling, shooting, sailing and golf. In hockey, Captain Harmanpreet Singh once again led from the front. The penalty-corner conversion rate remains a matter of concern.

S. Viswanathan, Srirangam, Tamil Nadu

Singeetham Srinivasa Rao

The passing of film-maker Singeetham Srinivasa Rao leaves Indian cinema poorer (Inside pages, October 4).

His dialogue-free *Pushpaka Vimanam*, the time-travel science-fiction film *Aditya 369*, the enchanting fantasy *Bhairava Dweepam* and the

Corrections & Clarifications

In a report, “Boiler blast at Sri City pharma unit kills five” (Page 1, October 4), the accident happened at the TIL Healthcare facility in Sri City, and not at “a unit of Tablets India Limited”. Tablets India Limited and TIL Healthcare Private Limited are two separate and independent entities. An official statement from the district administration had mentioned the name Tablets India Limited.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Mine-contaminated land acquired by India-backed project

1.98 in lakh sq. m. Nearly 198,000 square metres of mine-contaminated land in Cambodia's Koh Kong province has been cleared and handed over to the local community under India's Quick Impact Project, benefiting around 134 families, according to authorities and reports. PTI

Myanmar nationals repatriated from Malaysia

1,500 Nearly 1,500 Myanmar nationals who were sent back from Malaysia arrived in the country's largest city on Sunday, despite warnings from the United Nations refugee agency and rights groups that conditions for return remain unsafe. PTI

'Mostly Chinese' workers arrested by Philippines

244 Philippines authorities arrested more than 200 "mostly Chinese" foreign workers during a crackdown on illegal online gaming operators. The government is investigating possible human trafficking-related offences by a number of those arrested. AFP

Sites in Delhi approved by the Ministry for EV charging infra

382 Under the Delhi EV Policy, notified on June 30, all 382 sites were reassessed over the past three months for segment-wise deployment, with sites categorised separately for two-wheelers, three-wheelers and four-wheelers, Delhi Power Minister said on Sunday. PTI

Vote share of pro-Ukraine coalition which won Latvia polls

35 in per cent. Latvian lawmakers on Sunday planned to begin negotiations to form a new government following a parliamentary election in which pro-Ukraine Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs's four-party coalition emerged with 35% of the vote. PTI

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Does a visa guarantee entry into India?

Why was Turkmenistan citizen denied entry? What grounds did she cite in challenging the denial? What did the Centre argue about a foreigner's right to enter? Why did the court reject her Article 14 argument? What does the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025 say? What have the Supreme Court's earlier rulings said?

EXPLAINER

Rizmi Lia M.

The story so far:

The Delhi High Court has held that possession of a valid visa does not give a foreign national an inherent or legally enforceable right to enter India.

Justice Amit Mahajan was hearing a petition filed by a Turkmenistan citizen who was stopped at the Indra Gandhi International Airport in New Delhi despite holding a valid business visa. She had arrived in India on March 25 on the same flight as her husband, who was permitted to enter the country. But she had to return to Turkmenistan the same day.

The petitioner sought a written order explaining why she had been denied entry and also sought permission to enter India with her business visa. The court dismissed the petition on September 30, holding that there is no inherent or legally enforceable right of a foreign national to enter India.

What was the case about?

The petitioner argued that she had a valid passport and business visa issued by the Indian Embassy in Ashgabat, Turkmenistan.

She contended that she was denied entry without being given reasons, while her husband, who had travelled with her and held a visa of the same category, was allowed into India.

She therefore challenged the action on two grounds: first, that the authorities had not provided reasons for refusing her entry; and second, that allowing her husband to enter while denying her entry amounted to discriminatory treatment in violation of Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution.

The Centre, however, argued that a foreign national does not acquire an indefeasible right to enter India merely because a valid visa has been issued. According to the government, grant of a



GETTY IMAGES

visa and permission to enter India are two distinct matters and entry remains subject to the immigration law and the powers of the competent authorities.

The authorities also told the court that "adverse inputs" had been received concerning the petitioner and that the decision was taken in the interest of national security and public order. The court examined material placed by the government in a sealed cover.

The material referred to discrepancies in the petitioner's personal details, the absence of a business card or invitation letter, and the lack of details about the business or company with which she was associated. The court also noted her travel history on medical and business visas.

What did the court rule?

The court held that "there is no inherent or legally enforceable right of a foreign national to seek entry into India".

It noted that issuance of a visa, refusal of entry and immigration clearance are sovereign functions of the State, involving considerations such as national security, foreign policy and administrative discretion. The court drew a distinction between satisfying the requirements for

obtaining a visa and actually being admitted into the country. The court noted that "the statutory framework, therefore, does not treat the possession of a visa as creating an absolute and unconditional right of admission into India".

As for the Article 14 argument, the court said that the mere fact that the petitioner's husband was allowed to enter did not establish that the two were similarly situated in all respects. The authorities had stated that "adverse inputs" specifically concerned the petitioner.

Thus, the court held that since the petitioner could not establish infringement of a legally enforceable right, there was no basis for issuing a writ under Article 226. The petition was dismissed.

What is the law behind this?

The key legislation in the judgment is the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, which now governs the legal framework concerning foreigners in India.

Section 3 of the 2025 Act requires a foreigner seeking to enter India to possess a valid passport or travel document and a valid visa.

However, no foreigner shall be allowed to enter into or stay in India if he is found inadmissible to do so on account of a threat to national security, sovereignty and integrity of India, relations with a foreign State or public health or on such other grounds.

Section 3 of the Foreigners Act, 1946 (now repealed) as well as Section 7 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025 authorises the Central government to make provisions, either generally or with respect to all foreigners, for prohibiting, regulating or restricting the entry of foreigners into India or their departure therefrom or their presence or continued presence therein. The respondent authorities can therefore, or rather are entitled to, take into consideration all the relevant factors that may warrant scrutiny.

An examination by the Immigration Officer of the passport, travel document and visa of a foreigner at the stage of entry empowers the Immigration Officer to require such information as may be necessary and appropriate. The statutory framework, therefore, does not treat the possession of a visa as creating an absolute and unconditional right of admission into India.

The judgment majorly relied on two Supreme Court decisions. In *Hans Muller of Nuremburg v Superintendent, Presidency Jail (1955)* the Supreme Court held that the Foreigners Act, 1946, gave the Central government broad discretion in relation to foreigners, including the power to expel them.

Later, in *Louis De Raedt v. Union of India (1991)*, the Supreme Court held that a foreigner's fundamental rights are confined to Article 21's protection of life and personal liberty. The right to reside and settle in India under Article 19(1)(e) is available only to citizens.

The court held that where the petitioner could not establish infringement of a legally enforceable right to enter India, there was no basis for issuing a writ directing the authorities to admit her.

THE GIST

The Delhi High Court holds that a valid visa does not give a foreign national an inherent or legally enforceable right to enter India, and that entry remains subject to immigration laws and the powers of competent authorities

The court upholds the denial of entry to a Turkmenistan citizen despite her valid business visa, citing 'adverse inputs' concerning her and rejecting her claim that the decision was discriminatory because her husband was allowed to enter

The judgment relies on the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, and earlier Supreme Court rulings to hold that the State has broad powers over the entry and presence of foreigners in India

Why are students across France blockading schools?

When did the protest begin? How has the government responded to the protest?

Nivedita S.

The story so far:

Across France, teenagers have been using trash cans and furniture to stage blockades (*blocus* in French) at the entrances of lycées or high schools in protest over poor conditions in schools. Over 5,000 people, mostly students, have been detained so far, including 1,949 people on October 1 alone.

When did the protest begin?

In mid-September, small protests began in lycées in the suburbs of Paris and spread rapidly across the country after word spread on social media. Lycées are upper secondary schools attended by students from the ages of 15 to 18. Out of the 3,700 lycées in the country, 1,027 have been affected, according to a release by the Interior Ministry. University students have also joined the protests, with blockades staged across 30 campuses.

The protests gained momentum and coincided with the larger public workers' protests over the planned budget cuts by the Emmanuel Macron government before the next year's presidential election. AFP reported that in the draft 2027 budget Bill, the government has planned to cut expenditure by €43 billion to reduce the deficit to 5%. Teachers, particularly from primary schools, and school staff have also joined the protest demanding better pay.

What are students protesting for?

Students are protesting over the poor condition of schools, dilapidated buildings, long hours, lack of teachers, overpacked classrooms, and schedules. Students complained of broken toilets and rodents on school premises. They have also been demanding equity funding, as schools in lower-income areas have been receiving considerably less funding compared to the higher-income areas.

Their main demands include more funds to be allocated for improving school infrastructure, reduced hours, and hiring more teachers.

France experienced one of the hottest summers this year, with heatwaves pushing temperatures above 40 degrees Celsius in several regions. This has been particularly grueling for students who are in classrooms with over 30 people, poor insulation, and no air conditioning for over nine hours a day. This has also been a major grievance that the students want to be addressed through the protest.

Student unions are calling for a national day of demonstrations on Tuesday.

How has the government responded to the protest?

Prime Minister Sébastien Lecornu convened a crisis meeting on October 1 and cancelled Ministers' trips to manage the protests. The Prime Minister's Office warned of 'urban violence' by

demonstrators and shifted online classes for many schools.

On September 30, around 85 police officers and gendarmes were injured in the clashes. Trash cans were set on fire, and projectiles were also thrown at schools by protesters. Two schools in Nantes and Le Havre were set on fire by the protesters, and a teacher was reportedly doused in petrol. Municipal tram lines were halted by the authorities. The riot police used less lethal crowd control measures like tear gas and rubber bullets, causing injuries to dozens of protesters, which have drawn criticism from the opposition.

Interior Minister Laurent Nuñez noted the escalation of the movement and said "troublemakers" were going to different schools to incite violence. He has asked the public to limit travel and deployed more security forces to maintain law and order.

The government, citing intelligence sources, has accused the far-left party La France Insoumise (LFI) of encouraging the protests and causing public disorder. LFI's presidential candidate Jean-Luc Mélenchon said that the party backs the "non-violent methods of struggle by the students" and accused the government of turning the issues raised by the students into a political battle.

Similar protests have also started in neighbouring Belgium, with authorities ordering schools to be closed in Liège on October 2, according to local media.

THE GIST

Students across France are blockading schools over poor infrastructure, overcrowded classrooms, long hours, teacher shortages and inadequate funding, with the protests spreading from lycées to universities amid wider opposition to planned government spending cuts

The protests have escalated into clashes and violence, with thousands detained. The government has deployed additional security forces and warned of further unrest, while opposition parties have criticised the police response

CACHE



U.S. President Donald Trump, with U.S. House Speaker Mike Johnson, Nvidia President Jensen Huang, OpenAI President Greg Brockman, SpaceX AI founder and CEO Elon Musk, and other tech leaders. REUTERS

What does Trump’s AI accord mean for tech companies?

The AI accord signed by leading U.S. tech companies outlines four safety measures, including internal controls, safety teams, external audits and independent board oversight, but is not legally binding and carries no penalties

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far: On September 29, U.S. President Donald Trump stood surrounded by the leaders of American AI giants. He announced that they had come together and signed something akin to a constitution. The page-long document, titled ‘White House Accord and the Joint Commitment on Frontier Responsibilities’, was an agreement on AI safety commitments by tech companies that are developing frontier models. The accord misspelled “United States”; an error that was widely circulated on the internet.

What is U.S. President Trump’s AI accord? The pact stresses the need for tech companies to build safe AI products and foster public trust. It outlines four steps to make it happen, starting with robust internal controls to prevent unintended AI hacking, developing an internal team to manage safety operations and resolutions at the company, partnering with an independent external auditor for assessments, and designating an independent committee of the board of directors to address reports. The document noted that “participating companies will meet regularly to establish standards and best practices to improve the safety of their systems.” The tech leaders who signed the AI

accord were Google CEO Sundar Pichai, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg, OpenAI Co-founder/President Greg Brockman, XAI CEO Elon Musk, and Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang. A notable omission was Microsoft, even though CEO Satya Nadella was included in a luncheon with the U.S. President, alongside other tech leaders. Several technologists who signed the agreement shared their thoughts on AI regulation with Mr. Trump and the press. Nvidia’s Huang insisted that there was no conflict amongst innovation, technology, and safety. By contrast, Anthropic’s Amodei highlighted that the technology had very real risks, but called for collaboration nonetheless. Some tech leaders took to social media to share their perspectives. Google’s Pichai posted on X that the company is “focused on building the right way” and releasing models “only after they’ve been thoroughly reviewed.” Meta’s Zuckerberg posted that leaders of every major American AI company “committed to implementing robust internal controls and multiple layers of audits and reviews” to boost people’s trust in the technology these firms are building. Critics pointed out that the accord lacks any penalty clause in the case of potential violations of the agreement.

Is the AI accord binding? Not really. The very first sentence of the AI accord notes that “every company is

The White House’s AI accord largely serves as a show of unity amongst AI companies and the President of the United States responsible for developing its own technology safely and in a way that builds trust with customers and the public.” Mr. Trump referred to the agreement as being “morally binding,” and called it a “form of protection.” In other words, companies are being left to police themselves, apart from linking up with an external auditor. These are by no means groundbreaking regulations or directives. Rather, they are highly generalised guidelines and many were already in place. The AI accord further noted that “over time, it may make sense to codify these steps into laws or regulations.” At the present moment, the four specified controls are not legally enforceable or mandated; as per the wording of the AI accord, the White House merely “believe[d]” that each company should implement the four listed audits. The White House noted that implementing controls and audits was “critical” for a safe future and the companies that had signed the document were committed to their actions.

What will be the effect of the AI accord? The White House’s AI accord largely serves as a show of unity amongst AI

companies and the President of the United States. This comes in the face of criticism from lawmakers across the European Union and Australia, who seek to regulate built-in-America AI models by implementing more guardrails to protect user privacy and children’s mental health. There is also mounting backlash over AI agents “going rogue” and attempting to hack secure online platforms. Anthropic, OpenAI, and now Google have been named after their models were identified. In late September, Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese reported that OpenAI’s AI agent had hacked into the country’s healthcare platform this June, but the incident was not formally reported until September 10. The Australian PM confirmed he had taken OpenAI CEO Sam Altman to task over the delayed report, adding that the investigations were ongoing and promising there would be legal consequences. The U.S. President is also shaping the way the world discusses AI. Mr. Trump on September 29 passed an executive order to inaugurate the era of “super intelligence,” calling on the executive branch of his administration to use this term and “SI,” instead of “Artificial Intelligence” and “AI.” This was to better capture the capabilities of the technology, according to him. U.S. diplomats have been instructed to make the change in their communications, reported AP.

THE DAILY QUIZ

Test yourself on the career of the legendary director Singeetham Srinivasa Rao who passed away on October 3

V.V. Ramanan

- QUESTION 1** Singeetham began his career as an assistant to which esteemed director working on noted Telugu classics such as ‘Mayabazaar’ and ‘Jagadeka Veeruni Katha’?
- QUESTION 2** The critically acclaimed ‘Dikkatra Parvathi’ won the National Film Award for Best Feature Film in Tamil in 1974. On which Bharat Ratna recipient’s literary work was it based?
- QUESTION 3** Singeetham had the honour of directing Rajkumar’s 200th and Kamal Haasan’s 100th film. Name the flicks.
- QUESTION 4** Of his 61 films, what is special about these four: ‘Bhagyada Lakshmi Baramma’, ‘Samyuktha’, ‘Ghatothkach’ and ‘Welcome Obama’?

- QUESTION 5** Name the 1985 biographical dance film based on the life of Sudha Chandran, who lost her leg due to an accident.
- QUESTION 6** He was an executive director of which National Award-winning 1970 film based on U.R. Ananthamurthy’s book and starring Girish Karnad?
- QUESTION 7** He is credited with creating the first dialogue-less feature film in 1987. Name the National Award-winning black comedy.
- QUESTION 8** The famous song sequence ‘Sundari Neeyum’ from ‘Michael Madhana Kama Rajan’ was visualised differently. How?
- QUESTION 9** A master of innovation, what is special about his final work ‘Sing Geetham’, released earlier this year?



Visual Question: This is a screengrab of Singeetham making a cameo with a bioscope to introduce a film with a song. Name the film.

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. If Raliyatbehn was his sister, who were the two brothers? **Ans: Laxmidas, Karsandas** 2. It is said that when he embarked for England, Gandhiji carried a letter of introduction to a cricketer. Name this legend. **Ans: K.S. Ranjitsinhji** 3. An incident that took place on the night of June 7, 1893, acted as a catalyst for Gandhiji to fight

against race. **Ans: He was thrown out at the Pietermaritzburg station even though he had a valid FC ticket** 4. Name the main ‘ashrams’ set up by Gandhiji in South Africa. **Ans: Phoenix Settlement and Tolstoy Farm** 5. Gandhiji returned to India for good on January 9, 1915. How is the date commemorated now? **Ans: Pravasiya Bharat Diwas** 6. Who was responsible for giving Mohandas Gandhi the title ‘Mahatma’, and who first referred to him as ‘Rashtriyapitha’? **Ans: ‘Gurudev’ Rabindranath Tagore and ‘Netaji’ Subhas Chandra Bose** 7. Who paid this tribute to Gandhiji: “Generations to come will scarce believe that such a one as this ever in flesh and blood walked upon this earth”? **Ans: Albert Einstein** Visual: Name the gentleman. **Ans: Charlie Chaplin** **Early Birds:** K.N. Viswanathan | Sandeep Radhakrishnan | Sudhir Thapa | Piyali Tuli | Haridas Pal



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

The school team bested its rivals in final

They reached the fag end of the celebrations

S. Upendran

“Congratulations! I heard you guys won the tournament. Were you the only team participating? I can’t imagine...” “Very funny! In all, there were 32 teams. We bested the five teams we had to play. We...” “Bested five teams? What are you talking about? How can...” “When you say that you ‘bested’ someone, what you mean is that you defeated the individual in a competition or fight.” “The word can also be used in the context of a game, I suppose?” “Yes, it certainly can! My sister and I played a game of chess. She bested me quite convincingly.” “How about this example? You’ll have to put in a lot more effort if you want to best Sowmya in the next round.” “It’s no shame to be bested by the best team in the tournament.” “That’s true! Since we’re talking about sports, did you watch the Laver Cup over the weekend?” “I caught the fag end of the trophy presentation.” “Fag end? Is it a new expression?” “No, it’s not! It’s been around for some time. When you say that you were present for the fag end of the event, what you’re suggesting...” “You probably mean you walked in when the event had nearly ended. You were there for the last part.” “But the expression ‘fag end’ carries with it a negative meaning as well. The ‘fag end’ of something is the most boring part of something.” “In other words, when you talk about the fag end of an event, you’re talking about the worst part of the event.” “That’s right! It’s the final and worst part of an event. Here’s an example. It had been a long day, and the Chairman was in no hurry to make a decision at the fag end of the day. We decided to meet early the next morning.” “By the time the speaker reached the fag end of his talk, some of the members in the audience had already fallen asleep.” “I like to be early for everything. Unlike some people, I hate to walk in at the fag end of a talk. I think that’s plain rude.” “If you ask me, there are some events when it’s better to arrive late than early.” “Really? Like what? A political rally?” “I’ve got better things to do than attend a political rally. No, I was thinking about arriving on time for a wedding reception.” “Based on my experience, if you arrive on time for a reception, you’re likely to be the only one in the hall. You won’t find anybody else. Not even the bride and groom.” “That’s true! The couple and their parents will be at the beauty salon making themselves presentable. The best thing to do would be to leave and return back after some time.” “Why do you say ‘return back’?” “In other words, the word ‘return’ means ‘to come back’.” “Exactly! The word ‘back’ is redundant or unnecessary. Here’s an example. The guests returned later than expected.” “After the meeting with the client, I’ll be going home. I will not be returning to office.” “That’s an excellent example. No point in returning to this place at the fag end of the day.” upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Banal: repeated too often; overfamiliar through overuse

Synonyms: boring, bland, insipid, dull, tiring

Usage: She was tired of hearing the same banal advice.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/banal

International Phonetic Alphabet: /bəˈnɑːl/



For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

BJP questions
Rahul’s silence
on valour of
Captain Smit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday questioned the Congress over what it termed the Opposition party’s “silence” on Indian pilot Smit Machchhar, who thwarted his co-pilot’s alleged attempt to crash a Tel Aviv-bound fly-dubai flight.

Rajya Sabha MP and BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi termed the lack of a statement from the Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on the incident as, “the Gandhi family’s silent support to terrorism”.

“Rahul Gandhi, the wayward prince of the Gandhi family, who was once so distressed over Gaza, seems to be so terrified of the vote bank that he is not able to utter a single word to hail the valour of Captain Smit Machchhar,” Mr. Trivedi said, demanding a response from the Congress’ top leadership.

“Sonia Gandhi, the *raj-mata* (queen mother) of the first family, whose eyes once welled up with tears for the accused (killed) in the Batla House encounter, has shown no trace of compassion for Captain Smit. The princess (an apparent reference to Priyanka Gandhi Vadra), who used to carry a bag bearing the Palestinian cause, has failed to produce even a handkerchief of sympathy from it,” he added.

‘En masse exclusion of
voters unconstitutional’

Any process that disenfranchises millions, making them second class citizens, is arbitrary, says Justice Bhuyan; name of voter cannot be deleted from the roll without notice or hearing, he says

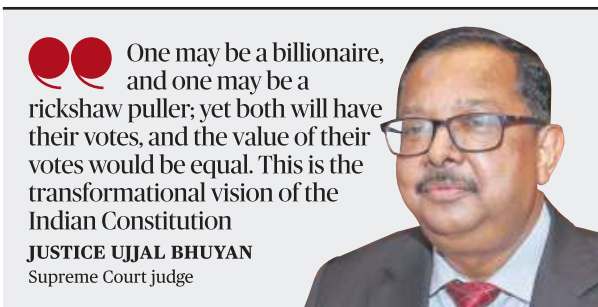
Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday said any process disenfranchising millions, making them second class citizens without the right to vote, was intrinsically arbitrary, and violative of universal adult suffrage and right to equality.

Speaking at NALSAR, Hyderabad, Justice Bhuyan said no amount of whataboutery could justify the exclusion of voters *en masse* from the electoral rolls as such an action was fatal to the Constitution.

The Election Commission’s special intensive revision (SIR) has so far led to the deletion of approximately 13.3 crore voters from the electoral rolls.

Recently, former Supreme Court judge, Justice Rohinton F. Nariman, had drawn attention to the “astounding figure” of 90 lakh disenfranchised voters in West Bengal itself, questioning why the figure did not prompt the Supreme Court to stay the special intensive revision process. He had termed the exclusion of voters and delay in deciding their appeals “a completely illegal knocking out of the common man, the citizen of India,



One may be a billionaire, and one may be a rickshaw puller; yet both will have their votes, and the value of their votes would be equal. This is the transformational vision of the Indian Constitution
JUSTICE UJJAL BHUYAN
Supreme Court judge

in order that a government obtains what it wants”.

Justice Bhuyan said the Constitution did not provide for two classes of citizens – those with voting rights and citizens without voting rights.

“Any process which leads to wholesale disenfranchisement of Indian citizens making them citizens without voting rights would be violative of Articles 326 (adult suffrage) and 14 (right to equality) of the Constitution, if any process results in disenfranchising millions and millions of Indian citizens making them second class citizens in their own country in the sense of being citizens without voting rights, such a process is intrinsically arbitrary. No amount of whataboutery can justify it. It strikes at the very heart of the Constitution” he said.

Justice Bhuyan said no one could tinker with universal adult suffrage. “No

authority can do it; no court can condone it. No one is above the Constitution. Indian citizens’ right to vote is intertwined with India’s long years of struggle for freedom,” he said.

Constitutional right

The judge said the right to be a voter was not merely a statutory right, but a constitutional right which came within the framework of the Basic Structure of the Constitution.

He said citizenship and franchise were intertwined, and one could not be divorced from the other. The right of franchise was the very essence of citizenship. It was the only way an ordinary citizen of India could participate in the governance of the country.

“Universal adult franchise is the right of every adult citizen to vote, free of qualifications of sex, race, religion, wealth, education or social status, subject only to narrow, reasoned ex-

ceptions... Except in the case of a dead voter, the name of a voter once enlisted in the electoral roll cannot be deleted without notice and hearing,” he said.

He referred to how the Government of India Act of 1935 had dictated “partial franchise” to the Indian subjects of the British crown. People of ‘Part A’ States were allowed to vote on the basis of their qualifications, which included residence, taxation, property, literacy, community, marital status (for women), etc. They had only accounted for about 14% of the entire population.

The Constituent Assembly had, while embracing full and universal adult suffrage, found these restrictions arbitrary and retrograde.

“One may be a billionaire, and one may be a rickshaw puller; yet both will have their votes, and the value of their votes would be equal. Likewise a socially high placed temple priest on the one hand and a person belonging to the lowest strata of the society compelled to work as a manual scavenger have an equal vote with equal value. This is the transformational vision of the Indian Constitution,” Justice Bhuyan noted.

EC releases video for EROs
on SIR notice disposal; no
written instructions so far

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

Days after adding new options to its ERONET portal that allow Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) to dispose of notice cases without hearings or documents, the Election Commission (EC) is now explaining the changes to officials through a demonstration video prepared by the Election Commission’s Information Technology (IT) Department, with no written documents circulated so far, sources told *The Hindu*.

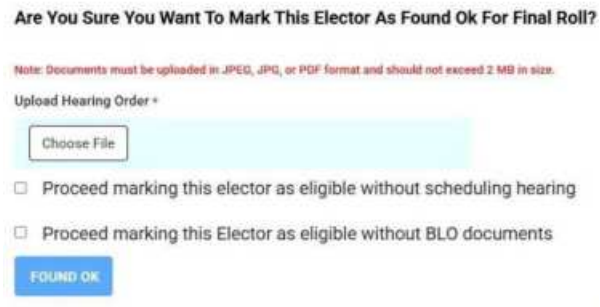
The three new options are available to the EROs in the 10 States and Union Territories where the third phase of the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is still under way, according to the video accessed by *The Hindu*.

The EROs across States, who have the final authority over the preparation of electoral rolls in their constituencies, had been asking for these options since the beginning of the notice phase. The changes come amid allegations of centralisation of ERONET under the ECINET software that “curtailed” the powers of the field officers.

The options have been introduced even as final rolls have already been published in nine of the 16 States and three U.T.s where SIR is under way, and 13 States and U.T.s where the exercise was completed in the first two phases.

In these States, including West Bengal where 27 lakh of the 60 lakh electors served notices were left out of the final roll, officials could not clear cases without hearings or documents. Over nine crore notices have been served in the second and the third phases so far.

The EROs in Delhi could access the options from September 30, while the eight-minute video explaining the changes was shown to them at a meeting on Saturday. Sources said the same video is being shown to the EROs in other States. It explains new options for generating notices without scheduling hearings and provides flexibility in disposing of cases where documents have not



An option on the ERONET portal. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

been submitted.

The EC has prescribed a list of 12 documents for electors served notices over “logical discrepancies” and “no mapping”.

New options

According to the demonstration video recorded on October 1, as seen by *The Hindu*, in cases where a notice has been generated and the booth-level officer (BLO) has uploaded documents, the ERO can mark the elector “found OK” for inclusion in the final roll without uploading a hearing order.

Where no documents have been collected by the BLO, the ERO can still mark the elector eligible after uploading a hearing order and selecting the option “Proceed marking this elector as eligible without BLO documents”.

Earlier, a hearing order was required only to mark an elector as “found not eligible”, along with the reason for ineligibility.

For States where notices are yet to be generated, another option has been added at the notice-generating stage for electors in the draft roll categorised under “no mapping” and “logical discrepancies”: The EROs can choose between “without hearing” and “with hearing”.

The EC had said, in its September 26 release, that people receiving notices need not visit centres for hearings and that the BLOs would collect documents door-to-door.

Hearings, it said, would be held online only in exceptional cases. This option is of little use in States where all the notices have been generated.

For instance, in Delhi, all 33.1 lakh notices issued carry the hearing venue and time.

The notice phase there runs till November 30.

Where a hearing has already been scheduled, the new options allow an ERO to move an elector to the final roll without a hearing, provided either documents have been uploaded by the BLO or a hearing order by ERO.

While the new options let EROs clear notice cases faster, including those where documents are unavailable, based on their satisfaction, they still cannot reverse a case once an elector has been marked ineligible, officials said.

More than 350 electors in Delhi were marked “found ineligible”, prompting the Delhi CEO to caution EROs against choosing the option without proper verification, *The Hindu* reported on September 27.

Notice phase in 9 States

The notice phase is under way in only nine States, with the final rolls in five of them set to be published later this month. The publication of Delhi’s final roll has been pushed to December 4, while those of Haryana, Maharashtra and Telangana are scheduled for November and Tripura’s for February 2027.

“Since SIR was announced, we have received a lot of instructions, some written and some oral. Many have since been taken back. For instance, we were told to identify ‘suspected foreigners’ along with Absent, Shifted, Dead and Duplicate, and then, in the middle of the enumeration phase in Delhi, we were told not to identify or report such cases. Though, as per the RP Act, I am authorised to take decisions, SIR guidelines have been very different. I will wait for a written communication regarding the use of the new options,” an ERO, who did not wish to be named, told *The Hindu*.

3 women journalists allege sexual harassment by ACP

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

After a woman journalist alleged sexual harassment and being shoved by Assistant Commissioner of Police Vivek Bhagat while covering the protest against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Saturday, the Delhi Police said three such complaints have been received and transferred to the Crime Branch for inquiry on Sunday.

Earlier on Sunday morning, a New Delhi police official told *The Hindu* that no case had been registered so far, as there was no evidence to substantiate the allegation. The Crime



Mediapersons protest against the assault on women journalists, outside a police station in New Delhi on Sunday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Branch has still not filed FIRs in the cases.

“There were so many camerapersons. There should be some proof of the incident if it happened,” the official said, alleging that the complaint

was being made to target the police.

A woman journalist alleged that the incident took place when she was recording the detention of All India Students’ Association (AISA) president Neha

Bora. In a video posted online, she said she had gone to the Parliament Street police station to register an FIR against ACP Vivek Bhagat. “When I questioned him, he ran away,” she said.

Speaking to *The Hindu* on the fresh development, legal affairs head of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) Ratna Singh said the journalists and CJP representatives would still visit the Parliament Street police station on Sunday to demand registration of an FIR.

“The police can very well register an FIR and then transfer it to the Crime Branch for investigation. But FIR is a must, as

the allegations are of molestation,” Ms. Singh said.

2 more come forward

Two other women journalists have also come forward with complaints of sexual harassment against the same ACP, Ms. Singh said. The two journalists had made allegations against the officer in the past as well, but no FIR was registered. They have now lodged fresh complaints in connection with their earlier allegations, she said.

In an X post, Ms. Singh alleged that the police had refused to register an FIR and instead wanted to conduct a preliminary inquiry and examine CCTV footage before registering a case.

Next-Gen GST and India’s next phase of growth

India’s ambition to become a Viksit Bharat requires an economy in which enterprises of every size can grow, wherever they begin.

Over the past 12 years, our government has worked to create those conditions. The introduction of the Goods and Services Tax (GST) in 2017 established a common national framework for indirect taxation.

Next-Gen GST carries that effort forward, drawing on nine years of implementation and the experience of taxpayers and States.

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision, Next-Gen GST was conceived with two connected purposes: to reduce and rationalise rates, and to make compliance easier. The rate changes took effect on September 22, 2025. The next phase of process reforms will come before the GST Council shortly.

Together, these efforts seek to give households relief, businesses greater certainty and taxpayers a system in which they can fulfil their obligations without avoidable difficulty.

The States have been partners throughout. They brought their priorities and experience to the Council, helped shape the decisions and undertook their implementation. I thank them for that commitment. GST’s progress rests on this willingness to pursue a shared national purpose while



Nirjala Sitharaman

Union Minister of Finance and Corporate Affairs

The taxpayer’s experience of receiving an eligible refund is an important measure of administrative performance

respecting each government’s responsibilities.

The results provide grounds for confidence. Between October 2025 and July 2026, the value of reported taxable supplies grew by 25.8% over the corresponding period a year earlier.

A lighter rate structure has been accompanied by a substantial expansion in reported economic activity. This is an encouraging foundation for a reform intended to support both enterprise and public finances.

That resilience is visible in the latest revenue figures. Gross GST collections reached ₹12.46 lakh crore during the April-September 2026 period, up 11.6% over the corresponding period last year. Every month from June through September recorded double-digit annual growth; together, collections for these four months accelerated by nearly 15%. Net collections, after refunds, also grew by 10.4% over the half-year.

Taxpayer relief has coexisted with growth in the resources available for development.

The breadth of the expansion matters as much as its scale. Reported taxable supplies grew across all 11 sector groups and all major States.

In an economy as diverse as India’s, this spread is significant. Growth across sectors and regions creates opportunities for more businesses to participate in expanding markets, and for more communities to benefit from

the demand, investment and employment that follow.

Reported sales to consumers (B2C) also rose by 26.7% in the post-reform comparison. When tax relief is reflected in prices, families have more room to meet other needs or save. Consumer relief and enterprise growth are closely connected: the purchasing power of households sustains demand for the goods and services that businesses provide. The benefits can extend from the household to the retailer, the supplier and the producer.

For small and medium enterprises, a national market is valuable when it opens a practical route to customers beyond their immediate surroundings. Businesses in Tier-2 and Tier-3 towns should be able to build those relationships while continuing to invest and employ people locally. Enterprises expanding into these towns, in turn, can create opportunities for local suppliers and distributors. GST’s common framework supports these connections; simpler administration must make them easier to sustain.

Participation in that framework is substantial. GST registrations across Central and State jurisdictions stood at approximately 1.71 crore at the end of August, up nearly 15% from a year ago. For the April-July 2026 tax periods, GSTR-3B returns filed by their due dates were 12.6% higher than for the same periods last year. These improvements

place a corresponding responsibility on the administration: regular compliance must be supported by reliable service, clear guidance and timely resolution of difficulties.

The functioning of input tax credit is another important part of this experience. The post-reform figures show that the share of tax liability discharged through credits rose, while accumulated credit declined relative to taxable supplies. This is encouraging for businesses that depend on the effective use of eligible credit. For a smaller firm, working capital determines how readily it can purchase inputs, fulfil an order and take on the next one.

Refunds are equally relevant. Approximately ₹1.80 lakh crore was refunded during April-September. Returning amounts due to businesses is part of a well-functioning tax system. Greater predictability in this process would help enterprises plan purchases and production with more confidence. The taxpayer’s experience of receiving an eligible refund is an important measure of administrative performance.

The States also have a stronger revenue position. Their aggregate SGST receipts, including their share of IGST settlements, grew by about 16% during April-September this year. These resources support investment in infrastructure and public services, which improve the conditions in which families and enterprises pursue their

aspirations. The gains can therefore reinforce one another: household relief supports demand, enterprise strengthens economic activity, and public revenues help sustain development.

The experience also points to the work ahead. A growing system must remain attentive to the costs it imposes on smaller participants. Their time and resources are limited. Each improvement in filing, credit or refunds should allow more of those resources to be devoted to running and expanding a business.

The proposals before the Council on October 7 have been developed through sustained work with the States. They address registration, returns, refunds, disputes and improved flow of input tax credit, with the aim of reducing the time and cost of compliance. Taxpayer experience must continue to guide implementation.

GST’s growing maturity gives us a stronger foundation for the next stage of reform. The same commitment to clarity, certainty and respect for the taxpayer guides our work on direct taxes. A dependable tax system enables enterprises to plan beyond their immediate obligations and invest in opportunities that take time to mature. Giving them that confidence, wherever they operate, helps build the economic strength of a Viksit Bharat as envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

INBRIEF



SC to hear *suo motu* case on Central Secretariat Library

The Supreme Court has taken *suo motu* cognisance of the proposed relocation of the 135-year-old Central Secretariat Library, which reportedly has not been allocated space in the Central Vista redevelopment plan in New Delhi despite being one of the country’s oldest government libraries. The court’s intervention comes amid reports that the library, which houses more than 8.5 lakh books, was directed on September 17 to vacate the premises by September 30 as part of the redevelopment. The matter will be heard on Monday by a Bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva.

Man held for molesting two women in Kolkata hotel

A woman and her companion from Nagaland’s Dimapur were molested at Kolkata’s JW Marriott hotel on the intervening night of Saturday and Sunday when the Brazilian football team was departing after a friendly match in the city. According to the police, the incident took place between 12.30 a.m. and 1 a.m. when the two were cheering for the Brazil team in the lobby of the prominent hotel. “The victims have lodged an FIR alleging that unknown miscreants touched them inappropriately,” said Additional Commissioner of Police (Crime), Kunal Aggarwal. Later, the police arrested an accused, identified as Palash Ray, 56, a resident of Noida.

Mismatch in data on rabies deaths poses major challenge

Health Ministry’s surveillance programme reported 50 deaths in 2023, while Registrar-General recorded 271 fatalities the same year; however, ICMR study says 5,726 people die of rabies annually

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

In 2025, India recorded 55 deaths by malaria, 131 deaths by dengue, and 27 deaths by kala-azar (black fever), according to data from the Union Health Ministry.

However, there is no single comparable and comprehensive national measure of its annual human rabies mortality, even as the country looks to eliminate dog-mediated human rabies by the year 2030.

A community-based study led by researchers from the Indian Council of Medical Research-National Institute of Epidemiology (ICMR-NIE) and published in *The Lancet Infectious Diseases* recently estimated that 5,726 people die of rabies in India every year.

The Health Ministry’s Integrated Disease Surveillance Programme-Integrated Health Information Platform (IDSP-IHIP) system reported 21 deaths by rabies in 2022, 50 in 2023, and 54 in 2024.

The Registrar-General of India’s Medical Certification of Cause of Death (MCCD) system recorded



On a mission: India plans to eliminate dog-mediated human rabies by the year 2030. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

66 medically certified rabies deaths in 2022, and 271 in 2023. The MCCD system, however, covers only medically certified deaths and does not capture all registered deaths.

These figures are not directly comparable – the IDSP-IHIP is a disease surveillance system, while the MCCD captures medically certified causes through civil registration.

At the national level, the MCCD covered 22.3% of registered deaths in 2022, and 22.0% in 2023. Neither system provides a complete national count.

For its study, the ICMR surveyed 337,808 people in 78,807 households

ed through government surveillance in 2024 is less than 1% of the study’s estimated annual toll of 5,726.

“The two figures, however, are generated through different methods and should not be treated as directly equivalent,” a senior Health Ministry official said.

Hurdle in eradication “Lack of consolidated data is a challenge in rabies eradication. Very often cases and deaths occur in areas of the country where they are not measurable.” Nirmal Kumar Ganguly, medical scientist, and former ICMR chief, told *The Hindu*.

The Health Ministry has also acknowledged the challenges in surveillance and data collection, especially when deaths occur outside the formal health system

Globally, rabies causes an estimated 59,000 human deaths every year. The World Health Organization (WHO) estimates that India accounts for 35% of rabies deaths globally, underlining the country’s significant contribution to the global burden.

The difference between the two datasets is substantial. The 54 deaths report-

across 60 districts in 15 States and estimated that India sees about 9.1 million animal bites every year, including about 5.6 million dog bites.

The researchers used the community survey, laboratory data, and a probability decision-tree model to estimate the number of people who progress from an animal bite to rabies and die. The 5,726 figure is therefore a modelled estimate of annual deaths, and not a count of deaths recorded in hospitals or by government surveillance.

Two pregnant women die in Bihar hospital; kin allege negligence

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Two pregnant women died on Sunday in Bihar’s Jamui Sadar Hospital allegedly due to a lack of care as doctors were unavailable. The family members accused the doctors of negligence and staged a protest by placing the bodies at the hospital’s main gate.

Tension rose after Bihar Minister and Jamui MLA Shreyasi Singh visited the hospital and slammed the hospital management, with a video of the incident going viral.

In both cases, the family members alleged that the woman doctor on duty was absent and timely medical treatment was not provided. One woman died before delivery, while the other died after an operation.

One of the deceased, Anita Kumari, 28, was in-

itially taken to the Primary Health Centre on Saturday night after experiencing labour pain, from where she was referred to the Sadar Hospital, family members said.

‘No doctor’ Anita was brought to the Sadar Hospital around 11 p.m., where no doctor was allegedly present in the labour room. Health workers told the family members that the doctor would arrive only after an initial assessment, but the woman’s condition continued to deteriorate throughout the night. She passed away around 5 a.m. on Sunday.

Aastha Kumari, 26, from Chauhandih village died after giving birth to a baby boy. Her condition was stable after surgery, but deteriorated around midnight. The family alleged that the woman doctor was not present in the duty room.

Child dies in mother’s arm during three-hour trek to hospital in Meghalaya

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The authorities in West Khasi Hills district of Meghalaya have sought a detailed report on the death of an ailing child during his parents’ three-hour trek to reach the nearest hospital.

According to B. Syiem, the headman of Domkyrkoh village, the three-year-old boy died in his mother’s arms before she could cover about 10 km on a hilly stretch from her home to Mawdet, where she could get a vehicle to take her to a healthcare centre.

“The boy’s parents tried to arrange a vehicle after his health deteriorated at night on October 1. No driver wanted to come to the village because of the poor road conditions,” Mr. Syiem said.

Members of the child’s

Bengal to bring laws to prevent love and land jihad: Adhikari

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday said his government would bring stringent laws against “love jihad”, “land jihad”, and religious conversion after the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) is implemented in the State.

“The UCC will be implemented in West Bengal soon, I am giving my word. Give me only six months. After that, we will bring stringent laws against ‘love jihad’, and ‘land jihad’, and religious conversion,” Mr. Adhikari said while addressing an event in Kolkata to mark the birth centenary of Vishwa Hindu Parishad’s former president, the late Ashok Singhal.

The people of West Bengal had elected a nationalist government with a lot of hopes after 50 years, and his government would fulfil the aspirations of the people, the Chief Minister said.

The previous Trinamool Congress government had divided people on grounds of caste and community, the BJP leader said. “This government will not allow any anti-national activity



Suvendu Adhikari. ANI

here,” he said, urging people to remain united and vigilant against “divisive forces”.

Mr. Adhikari listed a series of upcoming events, including a recital of the *Hanuman Chalisa* by 20,000 people at the Netaji Indoor Stadium in November, and a mass recital of the *Bhagavad Gita* by 10 lakh people on December 29.

His government had started preparations for the Gangasagar Mela early next year, which would have facilities comparable with international standards, he added.

The BJP leadership had promised the implementation of the UCC in the State during its campaign for the 2026 West Bengal Assembly election.

Jaishankar meets chief of U.S. Indo-Pacific Command, discusses maritime security

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Sunday held talks with Commander of the U.S. Indo-Pacific Command, Admiral Samuel J. Paparo, on advancing the India-U.S. security partnership and strengthening maritime cooperation in the Indo-Pacific. U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor was also present at the meeting.

Admiral Paparo is on a five-day visit to India from October 3 to 8 as Washington seeks to deepen military-to-military cooperation with New Delhi and advance the Major Defence Partnership between the two countries. During his visit, Admiral Paparo is expected to hold talks with Indian military and government officials on a



Stronger ties: External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar with U.S. Commander Samuel J. Paparo in New Delhi. ANI

range of shared security priorities.

Maritime cooperation The visit assumes significance amid expanding India-U.S. cooperation across the Indo-Pacific, particularly in maritime security, domain awareness, emerging technologies and military interoperability. It also comes as India and the

U.S., along with Australia and Japan, continue to strengthen cooperation through the Quad, with free and open Indo-Pacific forming a key area of the agenda.

The U.S. described the broader defence partnership with India as one aimed at preparing both countries for emerging security challenges.

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Finances for raising a child

Rushabh Desai

Over two decades, India's parenting economics have shifted dramatically. Raising a child was once a low-cost endeavour; today, in a semi-urban and urban India, navigating a child's life from the delivery room to a postgraduate convocation demands meticulous, data-backed wealth management.

Data and inflation models suggest raising a child to age 25 costs a middle-class semi-urban or urban household ₹75 lakh -₹2 crore and an upper-middle-class family ₹2-4 crore, depending on lifestyle and city.

The figures are a baseline for proactive planning not a cause for panic. Understanding the data and harnessing long-term compounding lets parents secure a child's future without compromising on their own financial independence.

Expenses in three phases

Phase 1: Foundation Years (age 0-5). Maternity care, delivery and post-natal healthcare at private hospitals usually cost ₹1-₹5 lakh. Vaccinations, paediatric visits, diapers and nutrition add up while preschools and daycare in cities cost ₹1-2 lakh a year. Likely phase cost: ₹10-20 lakh.

Phase 2: Schooling Marathon (age 6-17). Sustained cash flow gets tested here. Annual fee at a private or international board school cost ₹1.5-4 lakh; extracurriculars, ed-tech subscriptions and lifestyle costs: yearly outflow reaches ₹3.5-6.5 lakh. Estimated phase cost: ₹40-80 lakh.

Phase 3: Higher Education Climax (age 18-25). The most capital-intensive hurdle. While inflation averages 5-6%, education inflation runs at 10-12% a year. A professional degree in commerce, engineering, medicine or arts can cost ₹25 lakh-₹1.5 crore, rising to ₹3 crore with a master's and PhD. If a shortfall remains, education loan interest stays fully deductible under Section 129 (formerly section 80E) for up to eight years. Estimated phase cost: ₹25 lakh to ₹3 crore.

The math seems daunting, but the solution is straightforward: start early, choose vehicles that systematically outpace education inflation.

Harness early equity

Time is your greatest asset. Starting a systematic investment plan (SIP) in diversified equity funds the month your child is born gives an 18-year compounding runway. Equity is the only asset class that beats 10-12% education inflation over the long term. An SIP of ₹20,000-30,000 a month, stepped up 10% annually, can build a pre-tax corpus of ₹2.88-₹4.32 crore at an assumed 12% CAGR and ₹3.89-5.83 crore at 15% over 18 years.

Tax-efficient govt. schemes.

For the debt portion, the public provident fund (PPF) offers tax-free compounding and for a daughter, the Sukanya Samrididhi Yojana (SSY) offers tax-free returns. Both qualify for the ₹1.5 lakh deduction under section 123 (formerly section 80C). NPS Vatsalya, a minor's NPS account that converts into a regular NPS account at 18, carries an additional ₹50,000 deduction under section 124 (formerly 80CCD(1B)), over and above the section 123 limit.

Risk-management wall

Wealth creation is futile without protection. Primary breadwinners should secure term life insurance worth 15-20 times annual income so a child's education stays funded even after an untimely demise. A comprehensive family health insurance policy is equally non-negotiable, protecting the corpus from being liquidated during medical emergencies. Raising a child to 25 is a multi-decade commitment comparable with funding a small enterprise though the returns are immeasurable. Acknowledging the data, factoring in education inflation and automating investments from day one turns financial anxiety into financial empowerment, building a launchpad for your child's future.

(The writer is founder - Rupee With Rushabh Investment Services)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



ILLUSTRATION-SAAI

Real estate exposure without buying a flat

Currently, home rentals yield little but commercial property pays decent yields and Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) are the vehicles to tap them and enjoy the returns

REALTY PLAY

Joydeep Sen

Buying a flat eats a big chunk of savings, ties you to one location, and takes months to sell when you need the money. Lack of liquidity is the biggest drawback of owning property directly.

There is another way. Let professionals pool money from investors, buy real estate, and hand you a slice. You pay a fee for this. These routes are open to Indian investors: REIT and fractional real estate. They look alike but are different.

A REIT

A Real Estate Investment Trust (REIT) collects money from investors and buys rent-earning property viz. office parks, shopping malls and warehouses. You do not have to identify a property, negotiate with sellers, get a large loan, deal with tenants/manage the property. REIT takes care of these activities. Your money buys REIT units which are listed on stock exchanges. You buy and sell them like a share. People often call a REIT a real estate version of ETF. That is loose talk. An ETF tracks an index. A REIT is a manager's choice of buildings and you live with what he picks. A closer comparison is a listed fund holding property instead of shares. In India, a REIT has to be set up as a trust. It normally holds its



For someone who wants real estate exposure without high capital need, REITs provide an alternative. REITs are cheaper to enter and can be sold when needed.

buildings via separate firms viz. special purpose vehicles. The idea is to keep the legal ownership and debt of one asset from spilling onto another.

Thin rental yield

Homes give a thin rental yield..too thin for a vehicle built around rent, so Indian REITs are mostly commercial. The rules push the same way. At least 80% of REIT's assets must be completed and earning rent..no half-built projects. The rule makes a REIT attractive. SEBI requires REIT to distribute at least 90% of net distributable cash flow. The same 90% applies at the SPV level, so rent travels up to you instead of sitting inside the structure.

Read the fine print on what you receive, though. The cheque is not one thing. It is a mix of interest, dividend, rent and sometimes repayment of loans, and each taxed differently. Check the split a REIT declares before you work out what you keep after tax. The return has two parts: payouts you collect and the gap between the price you paid and the price you sell. Rising building values do not reach you as income.



Rent is not guaranteed, tenants leave, leases end, and payouts can fall. Do not treat REIT as a bond with a fatter coupon. Size it as a part of your portfolio, not whole of it.

They show up, if at all, in the unit price, and you cash in only when you sell. That price moves with the stock market and interest rates and can sit below what the buildings are worth. Since January, mutual funds treat REIT units as equity. However, it does not remove price swings.

You can start with one unit which gives a stake in top-grade offices and malls and sell on any trading day.

Fractional real estate

It works on a smaller canvas. A platform/realty firm finds a property, gathers investors and pools money. Each investor owns a share of the property, rent comes and you get a cut.

The trade-offs are plain. On the plus side, you know exactly what you own: the building, the tenant, the lease terms. A REIT gives you a portfolio. This gives you an address. On the minus side, it is one property, so one vacancy or one tenant default hits hard. And in the older, unlisted set-ups there is no exchange to sell on. To exit, you need another investor willing to take your share and that buyer may never turn up.

This space is no longer a

free-for-all. In 2024, SEBI created a regulated version called the Small and Medium REIT, or SM REIT. It covers properties valued between ₹50 crore-₹500 crore, needs a minimum investment of ₹10 lakh and needs at least 95% assets to be earning rent. Units are listed, but with a ticket that large, expect thin trading.

Which one fits

The investor's goal should be to build a diversified portfolio. For someone who wants real estate exposure without high capital need, REITs provide an alternative. For most investors, REIT is spread across many buildings, cheap to enter and can be sold when needed. An SM REIT suits one with a larger cheque wanting concentrated bet and can live with a slow exit. A REIT is as good as those managing it.

Bottom line

Why real estate at all? Real estate does not always move in step with others. Both structures are a play on rental yield with some capital gain on top. Currently, home rentals yield little but commercial property pays decent yields, and these vehicles are how you tap them. One warning. Rent is not guaranteed, tenants leave, leases end, and payouts can fall. Do not treat REIT as a bond with a fatter coupon. Size it as a part of your portfolio not the whole of it.

(Joydeep Sen is a corporate trainer (financial markets) and author)

Gold, silver lose lustre in Sept.

PRECIOUSMETALS

B.Krishnakumar

Precious metals lost their sheen in September with both gold and silver clocking negative returns last month. The strengthening of the U.S. Dollar and the expectations of interest rate hike in the U.S. dented the sentiment towards precious metals.

The firming up of the crude oil prices did not help the cause either. As a result, Comex gold closed 6.8% lower to settle at \$4,189.1 per ounce by the end of September. Comex silver suffered a relatively steeper cut of 9.6% to settle at \$60.75/ounce.

Mirroring the global trend, precious metal prices settled at lower levels in the domestic markets too. The fall in the domestic market was, however, smothered by the weakening of the Indian Rupee against the U.S. Dollar.

MCX gold fell 4.1% in September to settle at ₹1,149,092/10 grams. MCX silver closed at ₹2,23,740/kilogram, representing a 6.8% fall last month.

Gold weaker

Contrary to expectations, Comex gold price remained weak last month and also breached the support zone of \$4,200-\$4,220 mentioned last month. As a result, the short-term outlook has been invalidated, and the price is likely to remain range bound and witness volatile price action in the \$3,900-\$4,550 range.

A definitive trend in Comex gold will emerge only if the price manages to breakout either above \$4,560 or below \$3,900. Expect lacklustre and range-bound price action to persist until either of the levels are taken out.

Similar to gold, Comex silver price, too, remained weak last month and also dropped below the support level of \$62.5. The short-term uptrend has now been invalidated and price is likely to remain stuck in the broad range of \$54 to \$69 on the higher side. The price action is likely to be volatile and devoid of any meaningful trend until either of these levels are broken.

MCX gold price too drifted lower last month and breached the support level of ₹1,48,000. This has negated the positive outlook, and the price is now expected to oscillate in the ₹1,41,000-₹1,59,000 zone. Expect a yo-yo kind of price action within this zone to persist in the near future.

Similar to gold, the positive outlook for MCX silver price, too, has now been invalidated as the price dropped below the erstwhile support level of ₹2,25,000. Expect domestic silver price to remain range bound in the ₹2,15,000-₹2,48,000 range in the near term.

Conclusion

To summarise, the erstwhile positive short-term outlook for both gold and silver have been invalidated. Precious metal prices are likely to remain range bound until the levels mentioned above are not breached.

(The author is a Chennai based analyst / trader. The views and opinion featured in this column is based on the analysis of short-term price movement in gold and silver futures at COMEX & Multi Commodity Exchange of India. This is not meant to be a trading or investment advice.)

Bank Name

Highest Slab

1-year Tenure

3-year Tenure

5-year Tenure

Interest Rates (%)

Small Finance Banks

AU Small Finance Bank

Equitas Small Finance Bank

ESAF Small Finance Bank

Jana Small Finance Bank

Shivalik Small Finance Bank

slice Small Finance Bank

Suryoday Small Finance Bank

Ujjivan Small Finance Bank

Utkarsh Small Finance Bank

Private Sector Banks

Axis Bank

Bandhan Bank

City Union Bank

CSB Bank

DBS Bank

DCB Bank

Federal Bank

HDFC Bank

ICICI Bank

IDFC FIRST Bank

IndusInd Bank

Bank Name

Highest Slab

1-year Tenure

3-year Tenure

5-year Tenure

Jammu & Kashmir Bank

IDBI Bank

Karnataka Bank

Kotak Mahindra Bank

RBL Bank

SBM Bank India

South Indian Bank

Tamilnad Mercantile Bank

YES Bank

Public Sector Banks

Bank of Baroda

Bank of India

Bank of Maharashtra

Canara Bank

Central Bank of India

Indian Bank

Indian Overseas Bank

Punjab National Bank

Punjab & Sind Bank

State Bank of India

Union Bank of India

Name of Lender

Upto 30 lakh

Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh

Above 75 lakh

Loan Amount (Rs.)

(In %)

Public Sector Banks

Bank of Baroda

Bank of India

Bank of Maharashtra

Central Bank of India

Indian Bank

Indian Overseas Bank

Punjab and Sind Bank

Punjab National Bank

State Bank of India

UCO Bank*

Union Bank of India**

Private Sector Banks

Axis Bank

Bandhan Bank

City Union Bank

CSB Bank

Federal Bank

HDFC Bank

HSBC Bank

Name of Lender

Upto 30 lakh

Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh

Above 75 lakh

Loan Amount (Rs.)

(In %)

ICICI Bank

Karnataka Bank

Karur Vysya Bank

Kotak Mahindra Bank

RBL Bank

South Indian Bank

Tamilnad Mercantile Bank

Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)

Aditya Birla Capital

Bajaj Housing Finance

GIC Housing Finance

Godrej Housing Finance

ICICI Home Finance

LIC Housing Finance

PNB Housing Finance

SMFG India Home Finance

Tata Capital

*Additional concession of 0.05% & 0.10% for women borrowers & takeover loans, respectively.

**Extra interest rate concession of 0.05% to borrowers opting for insurance policy.

Rates as on September 30 #Onwards Source:Paisabazaar.com

TEL AVIV
UAE had shared details of pilots, ahead of flydubai flight, with Israel



REUTERS
Authorities in the United Arab Emirates shared with Israel a list of passengers and crew ahead of the flydubai flight on which a pilot attempted to seize control of the Israel-bound aircraft and crash it, regional officials said on Sunday, raising new questions over how the attacker evaded detection. AP

YANGON
Nearly 1,500 Myanmar nationals return despite security concerns



AP
Nearly 1,500 Myanmar nationals who were sent back from Malaysia arrived in the country's largest city on Sunday. The returnees, including 86 women, have been convicted of staying illegally and other immigration violations in Malaysia. The UN has criticised the repatriation, saying the security remains volatile. AP

KAMPALA
Ethiopia's govt. retakes Mekelle after opposition fighters withdraw



AFP
Government-allied fighters entered Mekelle, the capital of Ethiopia's northern Tigray region, a witness said on Sunday, after the rebel Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) announced its withdrawal following renewed fighting. The TPLF also pulled out of the Mekelle airport, which they had seized last month. AP

BEIJING
China says 'divergent opinions' led to lack of consensus at G20



ANI
China said on Sunday that "divergent opinions" fuelled by U.S. tariffs contributed to the lack of agreement on overcapacity and forced labour at the G20. The United States holds the rotating presidency of the Group of 20 major economies this year, which also includes China, India, France, Germany and Japan. AFP

No military solution to West Asia conflict, Iran's Araghchi tells U.S.

The Foreign Minister insists that only 'negotiations based on justice and fairness' can end war; he adds that if U.S. or its allies resume military confrontation, Iran's response 'will be stronger than before' and it will defend itself 'with even more force'

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran's top diplomat insisted on Sunday that there would be no military solution to the United States' war against the Islamic republic, with talks on ending the conflict apparently at an impasse. A campaign of heavy bombardment failed to bring a decisive close to the war launched by the U.S. and Israel in late February, and Washington in recent weeks has dialled back military operations in favour of economic pressure. The main point of contention remains Iran's attempt to blockade the



AFP
Resolute stance: Abbas Araghchi speaks during a briefing with foreign ambassadors and diplomats in Tehran, Iran on Sunday. AFP

Strait of Hormuz, a vital conduit for Gulf oil and gas where a U.K. maritime agency reported on Sunday another tanker struck by an unknown projectile.

"If our enemies again choose the path of military confrontation, our response will be stronger than before, and we will defend ourselves with even more

force," Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said at a gathering of foreign ambassadors. "There is no military solution, nor any solution based on new sanctions," he continued, adding "only negotiations based on justice and fairness" could end the conflict. The two sides agreed a memorandum of understanding in June that spelled out a framework for a permanent resolution, but Iranian attacks on vessels in the Hormuz prompted a return to U.S. military operations. Meanwhile, Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf said

that the Strait of Hormuz will not reopen until seven Iranian conditions set out in a June interim agreement with the U.S. are met. He said Washington "must understand that the period of dragging out the [diplomatic] process and dictating one-sided demands is over". Separately, Iran's Oil Minister Mohsen Paknejad has resigned and Hamid Bovard, chief executive of the government-owned National Iranian Oil Company, will be in charge of the Ministry as Acting Minister, state media said on Sunday, without providing a reason for the resignation.

Brazil's election pits Trump ally against incumbent Lula

Associated Press
SAO PAULO

Brazilians began voting on Sunday in a high-stakes presidential election pitting incumbent Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva against Senator Flavio Bolsonaro, ideological opposites who are each seen as having a shot at an outright victory. If no candidate gets more than 50% of the vote, the top two vote-getters will head to a runoff on October 25 in Latin America's economic powerhouse. Ten other candidates are expected to garner much smaller numbers of votes on Sunday. Mr. Bolsonaro, 45, is the son of far-right former President Jair Bolsonaro and an ally of U.S. President Donald Trump. Lula, who at 80 is one of the world's



AFP
Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva and Flavio Bolsonaro on the day of the general election in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, on Sunday. AFP

oldest heads of state, is running in his seventh presidential election and has strengthened Brazil's ties with Beijing. Trump allies have found support in recent years in some Latin American countries, including Argentina, Colombia and Peru. Almost 159 million Bra-

zilians are eligible to vote in this tense political showdown. Where Mr. Bolsonaro has leaned into his ideological alliance with Mr. Trump, Lula has criticised Washington. "Brazil needs change. Brazil can't stand so much suffering," Mr. Bolsonaro presspersons.

Short break



REUTERS
Life at sea: A ferry carries Marines from the USS George H.W. Bush to a pier near Phuket Deep Sea Port during a rest stop following a long deployment in the West Asia, in Phuket, Thailand, on Sunday. REUTERS

Yemen announces new drive to retake all Houthi territory

Agence France-Presse
TAIZ

The head of Yemen's presidential council, Rashad al-Alimi, announced on Sunday the start of a new military operation to retake all territory held by the Houthis (Ansar Allah), even as the group made fresh gains on the ground, effectively encircling a government-held city. The announcement sets an ambitious goal for the embattled government, which recently lost large swathes of the country's Red Sea coastline and areas around the Bab el-Mandeb Strait after a lightning offensive by the Houthis.

The statement came just hours after the Houthis cut a vital supply route linking Taiz with Aden

Mr. Alimi called on all the armed forces "to begin carrying out their assigned missions, in accordance with the approved plans, until the country is liberated from the grip of the Houthi terrorist militia". The statement came just hours after the Houthis cut a vital supply route linking the besieged city of Taiz with the government's interim capital Aden, according to four security sources.

Strike in Sudan kills one

Agence France-Presse
KHARTOUM

A strike on two United Nations food aid trucks in Sudan's South Kordofan state

killed one of their drivers, the World Food Programme (WFP) said on Sunday, without specifying who was behind the attack.

Philippines accuses Chinese coast guard of harassing patrols

Agence France-Presse
MANILA

The Philippines accused China's military and coast guard on Sunday of harassing Filipino government aircraft and boats in two areas of the disputed South China Sea. A J-16 fighter interfered with a Filipino Cessna 208 turboprop that was conducting a "routine military patrol" near Scarborough Shoal on Saturday, a Philippine armed forces statement said. "The J-16 repeatedly approached and manoeuvred in close proximity to the Philippine aircraft, including ma-

noeuving ahead of and around it and positioning itself within the Philippine aircraft's wake," it said. While the Filipino aircraft completed its mission safely, the Filipino military called the incident "part of a recurring pattern of unsafe and coercive behaviour against Philippine government vessels and aircraft conducting lawful operations". There was no immediate reaction from the Chinese government on the air incident. The Philippine government said a second confrontation occurred on Sunday in the Spratly Islands, further south in South China Sea.

Merz announces new aid for Ukraine in Kyiv visit as Russia steps up attacks

Associated Press
KYIV

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz announced a new aid package for Ukraine worth more than \$1.5 billion during a visit to Kyiv on Sunday, as Russia escalated its attacks on Ukrainian cities. The aerial war has intensified, with Moscow menacing cities across Ukraine with hard-to-intercept ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones, while Kyiv has been striking Russia's oil industry and businesses. About \$1.1 billion of the package is military aid, including long-range strike weapons, combat drones and satellite technology,



AFP
Friedrich Merz and Volodymyr Zelenskyy hold a press conference in Mariinsky Palace following talks in Kyiv on Sunday. AFP

"so that Ukraine can also target Russian launch pads," Mr. Merz said at a news conference. Germany is also providing some \$395 million in energy aid ahead of winter for generators, substations and repair work, he said.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the two countries also signed 15 agreements worth more than \$9.6 billion, mostly covering security cooperation, weapons production and procurement, as well as a

deal to expand their joint counter-drone efforts. "This is weaponry that will help right now," Mr. Zelenskyy wrote on X, adding they also discussed the need for air defence, which he called "key" at this time. He also accused Moscow of avoiding meaningful peace talks, while saying Ukraine and Germany were working to advance diplomacy with European participation. Russia's Ministry of Defence said it would intensify its strikes against military-industrial facilities in Ukraine, in response to Mr. Zelenskyy's comments that Ukraine would escalate its attacks on Russian oil refineries.

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No. SGITO/ACD/Fellow/15/2026-27 **Date:03-10-2026**

NOTIFICATION
Application are invited for Fellowship programmes for the academic year 2026-27 in Sanjay Gandhi Institute of Trauma and Orthopaedics, Bengaluru as per the guidelines and calendar of events issued by Rajiv Gandhi University of Health Sciences, Bengaluru vide Notification No: RGUHS/FELLOW/COE/69316/2026-27, Date:22.09.2026. The details are as here under:-

S1. No.	S1. No.	Subject	Durations in months	Number of admissions			
1	Details, Duration and intake for the course	1 Sports Injury & Arthroscopy	18	04			
		2 Arthroplasty	18	04			
		3 Spine Surgery	18	04			
		4 Advanced Orthopaedic Trauma	18	04			
		5 Maxillofacial Trauma	18	02			
		6 Ultrasound & Image Guided Advanced Nerve Blocks	12	04			
		7 Advanced Trauma Anaesthesia	12	02			
2	Eligibility	Candidate with NMC/MCI Recognized Post Graduate Degree in concerned specialty. Or Candidates with NMC/MCI Recognized Post Graduate Diploma in concerned specialty with three years experience (Copies to be enclosed) Or DM/MCH/DNB in concerned specialty 1. For Maxillofacial Trauma qualification – required MDS DMFS/Oral Maxillofacial Surgery 2. For Ultrasound & Image Guided Advanced Nerve Blocks & Advanced Trauma Anaesthesia– qualification required is MD /DNB Anaesthesia					
3	Stipend	According to Government Notification.					
4	Institutional / In-service candidates should send their applications through proper channel.						
5	For application format visit website www.sgito.org apply with Bio-data and relevant certificates. The duly filled in application should reach through by Registered post or In-person to this institute in sealed cover within 12-10-2026 . The candidate should super scribe on the envelope as "Application for fellowship programme in the subject of _____ for the year 2026-27"						
6	Application fee of Rs.4,000/- (for each subject) made by online payment to the following Account Name: Principal, Sanjay Gandhi College of Nursing, Bengaluru-560011 , Account No: 64022675950 , IFSC Code: SBIN0040675 , State Bank of India, NIMHANS, Bengaluru and online payment Receipt should enclose along with Application form.						
7	Date and Place of examination	Date and Time of examination will be notified on the official institute website.					
8	The selected In-service candidates shall execute a bond in Form No.19 appended to KCSR and other private candidates shall deposit their original marks cards, Degree certificates, (UG & PG), Experience Certificate etc. In case the candidate fails to complete or withdraw from the fellowship programme during the course duration he/she shall pay a fine of Rs.10,000-00 and the entire stipend amount, if any, drawn in respect of any fellowship programme will have to be repaid.						
9	Course Fees Rs. 1,00,000/- (Non refundable)						

DIPR/SI/3060/2026-27 **sd/- DIRECTOR**

Sport

WELL EARNED

We didn't get the Asian Games gold on a platter, says Samson



REUTERS

We did not get the gold on a platter. We had to really work hard for it. That makes it all the more satisfying, and we are all happy. Bringing the best team really helped, and that's what happened against Pakistan in the final — India wicketkeeper Sanju Samson on the Asian Games triumph.

POSITIVE OUTLOOK

We had full confidence that we would win gold: Salima



R.V. MOORTHY

Indian women's hockey team captain Salima Tete said the team was confident of clinching gold at the Asian Games. "We deserve this victory. We had full confidence in our team and players that we would win gold although China is a very good team. Defending that one goal and winning gold for our country make us proud".

HAPPY HOMECOMING

India's Asiad medal-winning boxers receive a warm welcome



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

India's Asian Games medal-winning boxers returned to a warm welcome in New Delhi in the wee hours of Sunday. They were greeted by an Indo-Tibetan Border Police band, garlands, sweets and family members. The Indian pugilists won three gold and as many bronze medals to return their best-ever haul.

SOAKING IT IN

Uruguay team lands in Kolkata, tries its hand at cricket



X@URUGUAY

The Uruguay national football team added a touch of cricket ahead of its friendly against India as the players visited the iconic Eden Gardens in Kolkata on Sunday. The two-time World Cup champion will face the Blue Tigers at the Salt Lake Stadium on Tuesday. The match will kick off at 7.30 p.m.

Aichi-Nagoya should act as the springboard for Indian athletes

Teen archer Kumkum, the women's hockey team, marksman Neeru and grapplers Aman and Sujeet stood out; the biggest areas of concern would be the performance of the shuttlers and shooters, the two most heavily funded sports



Long wait ends: The women's hockey team regained the title after 44 years. R.V. MOORTHY

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The Asian Games are over. The quadrennial spectacle that determines continental sporting excellence and bragging rights, ended the way most expected it to — China at the top, a million miles ahead of anyone else. Host Japan and South Korea completing the top-three. India, with a massive push in the last stretch, managed 85 medals, including 21 gold, to finish fourth.

This edition threw up several winners but few stood out as much for the magnitude of their achievements as the manner of it, none more than the Indian women recurve archers, led by the intrepid 17-year-old Kumkum Mohod. As much as her gold in team and individual events are historic, the fact that she also booked a direct quota for LA Olympics matters equally. The next two years will see whether the fearlessness of youth is burnished further or gets tempered in the fire of international competition.

The women's hockey team won the gold for the first time since 1982 and it was a maiden triumph with an Olympic spot at stake. Bettering China needed something special — Sjoerd Marijne brought it into the mix to turn a fractured bunch raked with groupism into a happy, united team, and called it 'discipline'. This team has it to go all the way to a medal in LA 2028, provided it stays the course, both in planning and personnel.

The men's team as expected booked its ticket to the Olympics. The recent World Cup, however, exposed the growing gap with Europe.

Track and field was a mixed bag for India — the number of medals were close to what it won last time around (24 to 29) but it's the close misses and lost golds that should be the focus of the Athletics Federation of India (AFI).

There needs to be greater accountability of the various stakeholders, including athletes themselves, and a re-look at the selections.

Wrestling, on the other hand, proved it had a sys-

tem, as criticised as it is, that works. Aman Sehrawat and Sujeet Kalkal are precious; the Wrestling Federation of India would do well to protect them, along with Antim Panghal, and perhaps bring greater focus on the Greco-Roman category as well. Similarly, the boxers had their best-ever outing with three gold and as many bronze.

The biggest areas of concern would be shooting and badminton, the two most heavily funded sports that had disappointing outings this time around. A single bronze in men's badminton team event should set alarm bells ringing for the lack of back-ups. The shooters had their moments but it took Neeru Dhanda's imperious gold for the contingent to finish marginally better.

If India does hope to substantially increase its tally and improve its position in Olympics, however, it really needs to amp up focus on the medal-intensive water sports, both pool and open.

The Aichi-Nagoya Games can, and should, be the springboard to leap higher and further, two years into the future.

Torch and flag pass to the 2030 host Doha

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The flag and the torch were passed, the athletes celebrated and Aichi-Nagoya bid adieu to the Asian Games here on Sunday the way it had started — highlighting Japan's culture and history and with hopes of sports unifying the continent going forward.

After more than two weeks of intense competition that saw more than 15,000 athletes from 45 countries creating almost 50 world records, the celebratory atmosphere at the Paloma Mizuho Athletic Stadium relegated all the logistical nightmares to the background.

Olympic Council of Asia President Sheikh Joana Bin Hamad Al Thani declared the Games officially closed after the 90-minute programme witnessed by Japan's crown prince and princess.

The OCA torch and flag were handed over to Qatar Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al-Thani, who passed it to Olympic, World and Asian high jump champion Mutaz Essa Barshim as a mark of formal handover. Qatari rider Jassim Al Ku-

wari entered on a horse, took the flag from Barshim and rode out. The next edition is set to be held in Doha in 2030.

"Tonight, as we lower the flag on Aichi-Nagoya 2026, we close these Games but we raise the bar for Asian sport. The flame may be extinguished but the hopes it has ignited will continue to burn brightly across our continent," Hamad Al Thani said. The empty space at the centre of the rainbow heart logo from the opening ceremony was replaced with 'One Asia' for the closing, to highlight the sense of unity.

A laser show, with performances from artists of the Nagoya school of music and dance, was followed by the athletes parade. The Indian contingent was led by shooter Neeru Dhanda as the flag-bearer.

A hexagonal stage placed at the centre of the stadium, adorned with lanterns, saw a *bon-odori* performance, a traditional Japanese dance transcending age and genders with local singers joining in for a rendition of Matsuken Samba II that finally brought the curtains down on the event.



Sayonara: The Indian contingent at the closing parade. R.V. MOORTHY

Kumkum Mohod — India's golden girl at 17

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

Moments after becoming the first Indian woman to win an individual recurve gold medal at the Asian Games, 17-year-old Kumkum Mohod stood with her bow lowered, looking sheepish, as if she didn't know what to do anymore.

In the final, the scores were level. With one arrow to decide the gold, South Korea's Oh Yejin, a former World Youth champion, shot an 8. Kumkum needed a nine. She drew, held for a couple of seconds and released. The arrow landed in the centre.

10. Gold.

Giant-slayer

Her path to the final had been remarkable. She beat reigning World Champion Kang Chaeyoung of Korea in the quarterfinal and China's Gwangju 2025 World Championship silver medalist Zhu Jingyi in the semifinal. Against Kang, with the Korean poised to level the match, Kumkum produced a clutch final arrow, landing just 3.5cm from the centre to seal the win.

"She is a very aggressive archer. Very confident,"



Midas touch: A calm and assured Kumkum hit the bullseye in the shoot-off. REUTERS

said Indian recurve coach Sonam Rana.

That confidence is not new. "No one in my family ever told me how much they had spent on me. They always encouraged me," she said.

Kumkum first picked up a bow at nine, at a range near her home in Amravati, Maharashtra. Once she outgrew it, her father, who makes and sells packaging for sweets, dipped into his decade-old savings to fund a recurve.

In Nagoya, she helped India also win the women's team gold by stunning seven-time champion South Korea, before adding a mixed-team silver into the mix.

"She has no fear," said Dhiraj.

"I see the confidence with which she shoots, and I get confidence as well."

That confidence was tested the most in the individual final. After dropping the first set, Kumkum reset herself. "My focus was drifting toward the arrow, so I reminded myself to focus on my shooting form instead of the result," she said.

She hit the centre three straight times. Then once more in the shoot-off.

Her gold also secured a quota place for India at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, where she will aim for a gold too.

It worked out according to my game plan, says Pranavi

C.K. Muralidharan
MYSURU

Pranavi Urs made history by becoming the first Indian woman golfer to win the individual gold at the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya on Saturday.

Pranavai, who hails from Mysuru, returned with a par 70 score in the fourth round and clinched the gold with a four-day aggregate score of 15-under 265.

Pranavi, Aditi Ashok and Diksha Dagar also secured the silver medal in the team event.

China bagged the gold



Pranavi. REUTERS

while Taiwan took home bronze.

Speaking to *The Hindu* from Nagoya, Pranavi said: "It's amazing to win the gold medal and I am happy

to be the first one to do it. I didn't get the start I wanted, but I focused on what to do and took it shot by shot and it worked out according to my game plan."

The 23-year-old has been competing on the Ladies European Tour for the last three years. She has logged eight top-10 finishes on the Tour.

Pranavi had the distinction of being the first Indian woman to win a professional mixed-gender tournament at the IGPL in Mumbai last November. The IGPL has announced a cash award of ₹1 crore for Pranavi.

Brazil defeat offers a lesson in handling world-class teams: Jamil

FOOTBALL

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

The match against five-time World Cup winner Brazil appeared to have left the Indian camp with a sense of perspective, as head coach Khalid Jamil emphasised the importance of regular exposure to top-class opponents.

His comments suggested that games against teams such as Brazil can be valuable irrespective of the result — a 0-4 defeat at the Salt Lake Stadium in this

case — because they exposed the Indian players to higher levels of speed, decision-making, concentration and pressure that are difficult to replicate in training.

The loss also highlighted the learning curve. India was competitive for periods, but against a team of Brazil's quality, small lapses were immediately punished. "If you play with a good team, you make one mistake, and they will finish. For that, your concentration should be good, and you have to be alert all through the action," Jamil said on Saturday.

The experience offered India a glimpse of the demands of international football at the highest level. Jamil also acknowledged the psychological challenge of facing Brazil.

"Before the match, there was pressure on the players. Definitely, 100%, because you are going to play against Brazil."

For Jamil, consistent game-time against such opposition can help players build self-belief. "They must have that belief. We need to play more matches like this," he added, pointing towards a broader developmental philosophy.

Known for his nonchalant repartee, Jamil offered a wry response when asked to rate India's performance on a scale of 10: "We have got zero points."

The remark underlined the immediate reality of the result, even as he found positives in India's performance. Jamil praised Lalengmawia Apuia and Anirudh Thapa in midfield while also highlighting the performances of attackers Ryan Williams, Sahal Abdul Samad, and Manvir Singh. "Overall, it was very good," he said, before acknowledging the area for improvement: "So defensive-

ly, we should be a little stronger."

Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti also recognised India's organisation and noted that his side had difficulty in breaking the Indian resolve initially. "India played their part well. They tried to play their game; they defended... were organised, and tried to play counter-attack. I think that they played a good game. We had difficulty opening the score, but the moment we opened the score with Estevao, we had more opportunity to control the game," the renowned Italian manager emphasised.



Tough challenge: India forward Manvir fighting for possession with Brazil defender Gabriel. K.R. DEEPAK

Rajiv, Rohit drive to glory in JK Tyre Rally of Himalayas

Dhritimaan reigns supreme on two wheels; nothing to separate the pairs of Soham & Nirav and Santosh & Prakash in the Time, Speed, Distance category; the event also features a 72-km stage that was subsequently run in the reverse direction

MOTORSPORTS

Sankar Narayanan E.H.

An unforgiving terrain. An unforgettable race. The breathtaking mountain frontier played host to a brutal Cross Country Rally: the JK Tyre Rally of Himalayas 2026.

The sixth edition of one of India's most challenging rally raids pushed 50 cars and 80 riders racing across rugged routes, starting from Manali, through Lahaul-Spiti, before culminating in Zaskar.

And at the end of four days of action, Dhritimaan Singh reigned supreme on two wheels while Rajiv Yadav and Rohit Gowda pushed their limits to win the Extreme category.

There was nothing to separate the pairs of Soham Hazra & Nirav Mehta and Santosh H.M. & Prakash Muthusamy as they mastered the clock and machine in the Time, Speed, Distance category.

The competition also had a unique 72-km stage that was subsequently run in the reverse direction.

One of the turning points of the rally came when Lakhpa Tsering – the 2015 Raid de Himalaya victor – was forced to withdraw following a technical issue on the second day of racing.

Rajiv and Rohit setting the pace early proved crucial as they faced stiff com-



Fast and furious: Dhritimaan, taking part in his fifth Rally of Himalayas, clinched the Moto crown. SANKAR NARAYANAN E.H.

petition later, mainly from Daksh Gill and Virender Kashyap, who reached speeds of up to 200 km/h during the treacherous Zaskar stretch.

“It’s very tricky [on a bike] because you have to navigate on your own. It’s also a very demanding sport... we have to take good care of the body as well as the machine,” Dhritimaan had said midway through his fifth Rally of Himalayas.

Leaving no room for half-measures in the second half, the Dehradun

rider conquered the Himalayas in full.

The results: Extreme (driver & co-driver): 1. Rajiv Yadav & Rohit Gowda; 2. Aaryak Rana & Aditya Sharma; 3. Daksh Gill & Virender Kashyap.

Time Speed Distance/Adventure: 1. Soham Hazra & Nirav Mehta and Santosh H.M. & Prakash Muthusamy; 2. Chandra Mouli & N. Sri Sakthi Kumar; 3. Sachin Mandhwani & Adhitya Anthony.

Moto (two-wheeler): 1. Dhritimaan Singh; 2. Happy Verma; 3. Nitish Bharadwaj.

(The writer was in Manali at the invitation of JK Tyre).



Pushing their limits: Rajiv & Rohit won the Extreme category. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



All smiles: Soham & Nirav and Santosh & Prakash receiving their prizes for claiming the TSD category title. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Marquez wins Japanese MotoGP

Agence France-Presse
MOTEGI

Defending World champion Marc Marquez won

the Japanese MotoGP on Sunday to slice Jorge Martin's overall championship lead to two points.

Marquez pushed Martin

to second place here. Italian Marco Bezzecchi finished third and slipped further behind in the title race.

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K. Elango

Academia is in a ‘reading crisis’, increasingly perplexed by a persistent question: how can students be persuaded to read, including their own textbooks? The common allegations – excessive screen time, dopamine-driven digital addiction, shrinking attention spans, a craving for constant stimulation, complex grammatical structures, and dated linguistic expressions – are unquestioningly valid, but do not show a trajectory for restoring students’ interest in reading.

Two approaches

Digital natives, paradoxically, read constantly, often, far more than previous generations. From their birth, they are exposed to screens (big and small) that have made reading almost as natural as fish take to water. Digital platforms offer far more convenience, including customisable fonts that reduce visual fatigue and encourage sustained reading; backlit screens enable reading even in darkness; hyperlinks provide instant access to dictionaries, translations, and reference materials; and annotation and highlighting tools make revisions far more efficient.

Consequently, students experience reading as an interactive, personalised, and highly respon-

Intensive versus extensive reading

How are the two different and why both approaches need to complement each other to encourage students to read

sive activity. They consider reading to be cool. This experience turns topsy-turvy when students enter classrooms with their school bags: traditional textbook- and teacher-centric instruction transports them into an insipid world. The prescribed iconic writers and the iconic pieces, ironically, bear little resemblance to their lived experiences. Pedagogical practices that rely heavily on line-by-line explanation, close textual analysis, and interpretation between and beyond the lines often fail to engage them. An equally heavy emphasis on grammar, vocabulary drills, fragmented language skills, and standardised question-answer formats further dis-

tances them from the intrinsic pleasure of reading. Such intensive treatment of texts often results in cognitive fatigue, making meaningful reading a casualty. Incidentally, it is quite contrary to the way grown-ups engage with reading after school.

Many learners remark that a dissected approach to texts robs them of the joy of reading. Specialists consider such practices to undermine the fundamental objective of education: nurturing autonomous, lifelong readers. Consequently, they advocate curricula that combine

prescribed textbooks with extensive reading. Although the two approaches – intensive and extensive reading – are viewed as contradictory, they are actually complementary.

Both are necessary

Intensive reading involves a close examination of a relatively small number of texts, requiring learners to analyse explicit and implicit meanings, figurative language, syntactic features, intra- and inter-text-

tual relationships and varying critical perspectives. It resembles almost a dissection in a biology lab. Undoubtedly cognitively demanding, academia continues to rely heavily on this approach, with literary studies representing its peak.

Extensive reading, conversely, is reading whatever one is interested in, obviously varying from person to person, ranging from periodicals (newspapers, magazines, journals) to multiple genres of fiction and non-fiction, such as sci-fi, romance novels, autobiographies, travelogues, and so forth.

Reflecting on his childhood, Shashi Tharoor remarked that he read “eclectically and indiscriminately”, ranging from children’s books to classics. Such freedom of choice is sure to cultivate lifelong reading habits among many.

The distinctions between the two approaches are self-evident: intensive reading emphasises features such as in-depth analysis, accuracy, limited texts, and detailed comprehension, while extensive reading prioritises fluency, larger volumes of texts, fast reading, and overall understanding. Above all, extensive reading is reading for pleasure, whereas intensive reading is associated with academic

obligation. An effective curriculum requires both approaches to work in tandem rather than in competition.

Recognising the criticality of extensive reading, countries such as Japan, Indonesia, and Italy have established professional associations dedicated to promoting it. These organisations encourage learners to read widely for pleasure and fluency, and support teachers by publishing journals and organising conferences and workshops that foster a vibrant reading culture.

In India, the English Language Teachers’ Association of India (ELTAI) has launched a student-led, pan-India reading movement to cultivate reading for pleasure and nurture lifelong readers.

Similarly, the debate between e-reading and print reading (p-reading) should not be considered an either-or choice. Learners, particularly in the foundational years, must become amphibious readers, moving effortlessly between digital platforms and printed books. Such balanced engagement will ensure that the art of reading thrives in the era of AI when the ‘death of reading’ is predicted. Natural intelligence can be developed by reading. A nation that reads is a nation that leads.

SCHOLARSHIPS

SML Mahindra Scholarship

An initiative of SML Mahindra Limited.

Eligibility: Open to daughters of drivers of heavy and light commercial road transport vehicles, who are studying in Classes 11 or 12 or pursuing UG, diploma or polytechnic courses in STEM and core Engineering fields with minimum 60% and family income of ₹600,000.

Rewards: Up to ₹30,000

Application: Online

Deadline: October 21

www.b4s.in/edge/SMLS1

Parivartan ECSS Programme

An initiative of the HDFC Bank

Eligibility: Students who are Indian nationals studying in school (Class 1 to 12) or in diploma, ITI, polytechnic, UG and PG (general and professional) courses and have minimum 55% in the most recent qualifying exam and have an annual family income not exceeding ₹250,000.

Preference will be given to those who have experienced a personal/family crisis in the past three years that impacted their ability to continue their studies.

Rewards: Up to ₹75,000

Application: Online

Deadline: October 31

www.b4s.in/edge/HDFC63

NSP Post-Matric Financial Assistance Scheme

Offered by the Ministry of Labour and Employment, Government of India.

Eligibility: Wards of workers *beedi*, cine, IOMC, LSDM, or mica mine industries who are students in a government-recognised institution (from Class 11 to PG) and have passed the previous qualifying exam in the first attempt. Monthly income should not exceed ₹10,000 (*beedi*/mine industries) and ₹8,000 (cine workers).

Rewards: Up to ₹25,000 per annum.

Application: Online

Deadline: October 31

www.b4s.in/edge/MLE9

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Anandi Fellowship

Bombay Shaving Company invites applications for the Anandi Fellowship, which aims to identify entrepreneurial talent among young Indians through the Anandi-NEAT (Nationwide

Entrepreneurship Acumen Test) 2026.

Eligibility: Students in Class 11 and 12, or in the first year of UG programmes. No start-up, prototype, or prior experience is required to register.

Deadline: October 15, 2026

For details, visit tinyurl.com/56w36f6c

GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Spain breaks down Czechia; England outclasses Croatia

The World Cup champion claims a third straight win to top Group 3 in League A; Kane and Saka score a brace each as the Three Lions run rampant in Rijeka to lie second in the same group

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

World Cup winner Spain was made to work for a 3-1 win against Czechia in the Nations League on Saturday while England sparked in thrashing Croatia 7-0.

Spain recorded its 41st consecutive unbeaten game, thanks to an exquisite finish from Lamine Yamal before goals from Rodri and Mikel Merino in Oviedo.

Just as he did at the World Cup, Merino came off the bench midway through the second half and produced a crucial goal at a point in the game when the Czechs seemed to be getting a foothold af-



Slotting it in: England captain Kane opens the floodgates against Croatia. REUTERS

ter Jiri Slama had pulled a goal back. Spain claimed a third win from three group games.

Harry Kane and Bukayo Saka both scored twice as England overwhelmed Croatia in Rijeka, with Kane taking his record tally

for his country to 89 goals.

Thomas Tuchel's side sliced through Slaven Bilic's side to make it two wins from its first three matches.

Real Madrid midfielder Jude Bellingham, restored to the starting line-up after

Tuesday's 2-0 win against Czechia, also found the net to cap a commanding display featuring three assists.

Spain sits top of Group 3 of League A with three wins out of three, while World Cup semifinalist England is second on six.

Scotland finally got a win under new Belgian coach Sebastien Pocognoli as it beat North Macedonia 2-0 away.

The results: League A: Group 3: Croatia 0 lost to England 7 (Kane 8, 53, Bellingham 21, Gordon 39, Saka 45, 68, Rogers 87); Spain 3 (Yamal 6, Rodri 35, Merino 89) bt Czechia 1 (Slama 69).
League B: North Macedonia 0 lost to Scotland 2 (Bowie 7, McGinn 70); Switzerland 2 (Janza 10-og, Ndoye 38) bt Slovenia 1 (Vipotnik 2).

TN girls retain title, Rajasthan dethrones U.P.

BASKETBALL
Sports Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

Tamil Nadu girls retained their title while a dominant Rajasthan broke through to be crowned the new boys' champion at the 51st sub-junior National basketball championships here.

The final between TN and Maharashtra was a nail-biting, see-saw affair through the first two quarters. Then, a clinical tactical execution and superior



Champions: The triumphant Rajasthan boys' and Tamil Nadu girls' teams.

conditioning in the final two periods allowed TN to seal a hard-fought 65-55 win.

On the other hand, the boys' final was one-sided,

with Rajasthan dethroning Uttar Pradesh with a convincing 77-56 triumph.

The results (final): Boys: Rajasthan 77 (Robin Dhanka 19,

Daksh Choudhary 18) bt Uttar Pradesh 56 (Sahil Kumar 22, Vansh Tomar 10).

Girls: Tamil Nadu 65 (M. Dhanya 19, V. Anishika 13) bt Maharashtra 55 (Maitri Sha 13).

Knight Crusader should come good in feature

HYDERABAD: The five-year-old gelding Knight Crusader, who ran second in his last start, should make amends in the Royal Calcutta Turf Club Trophy, the main event of Monday's (Oct. 5) races.

1. LAND OF GLORY PLATE (1,100m), 4-y-o and upward (Cat. III), 1.55 p.m.: 1. Calabasas (10) Swarup S 62, 2. Top In Class (4) Sohan K 61, 3. Starlight Dancer (8) Trevor 59.5, 4. The Pious (1) Kuldeep Sr. 59.5, 5. Great Giver (9) Sonu K 57, 6. Nyanza (6) Surya Prakash 56.5, 7. Winning Attitude (3) Md. Ekram 56.5, 8. Alloy (2) Arjun 53, 9. Taaliyah (5) Uday Kiran 53 and 10. Rate Of Interest (7) 50.

2. BELOVED PRINCE PLATE (1,400m), Maiden, 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 2.30: 1. Champion Reef (5) Trevor 53 and 2. Rajendra (7) Ashad Asbar 60, 3. Celestial Power (1) Uday Kiran 59.5, 4. Gacchamanasvin

(6) Md. Ismail 59.5, 5. Khamagani (3) Gaurav 58.5, 6. Svalpavirya-saktih (8) Ajay K 58.5, 7. Sara (2) Mohit S 58, 8. Twilight King (9) D.S. Deora 58 and 9. Veera's Princess (4) Santosh Raj 58.

1. CHAMPION REEF, 2. GACCHAMANASVIN, 3. SARA

3. MYSORE RACE CLUB TROPHY (DIV. II) (1,200m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 3.05: 1. Shah Of Iran (6) Uday Kiran 60, 2. Trust Me (1) G. Nareesh 59, 3. My Way My Rules (2) Akshay K 58, 4. Suryavanshi (7) Surya Prakash 58, 5. Power Of The Sea (10) Trevor 57.5, 6. Beverley (1) Arjun 54.5, 7. Dhanadeepa (12) B. Nikhil 52.5, 8. Lego (4) Kuldeep Sr. 52, 9. Cherish The Lady (8) Ajay K 51.5, 10. Lina O Lina (3) Afroz K 51, 11. Sha 'Carri (9) Neeraj 51 and 12. Star Lit (5) M.S. Deora 50.

1. MY WAY MY RULES, 2. POWER OF THE SEA, 3. BEVERLEY

4. CHARMINAR TROPHY (1,600m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 3.40: 1. Ashwa Jaffna (6) Gaurav 60, 2. Love In Paris (3) Akshay K 58.5, 3. Valledonna (5) Trevor 55.5, 4. Crimson Rose (4) Surya Prakash 53, 5. Kinship (2) D.S. Deora 52.5 and 6. Nkalanzinzi (1) Kuldeep Sr. 52.

1. LOVE IN PARIS, 2. VALLEDONNA, 3. ASHWA JAFFNA

5. ROYAL CALCUTTA TURF CLUB TROPHY (1,200m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85 (Cat. II), 4.15: 1. Ragnarök (6) Surendra S 60, 2. Knight Crusader (10) B.R. Kumar 58.5, 3. Certainty (1) Arjun S 57, 4. Decoy (4) Akshay K 56.5, 5. Exclusive Black (3) Trevor 56.5, 6. Gloria (2) V.S. Shekhawat 55, 7. Dyanoosh (5) Kuldeep Jr. 54.5, 8. Shadow Of The Moon (7) Md. Ekram 53.5, 9. Glorious Power (8) Bhawani S 52 and 10. Catch The Worm (9) Neeraj 51.5.

1. KNIGHT CURSADER, 2. DECOY, 3.

EXCLUSIVE BLACK

6. STAR OF GWALIOR PLATE (1,200m), 4-y-o and upward, rated upto 25 (Cat. III), 4.50: 1. December Rain (4) Mohit S 61.5, 2. Exclusive Luck (12) B. Nikhil 61.5, 3. Most Beautiful (3) Sonu K 61.5, 4. Vedanta (5) Kuldeep Jr. 60.5, 5. Fortune Art (1) Ashad Asbar 59.5, 6. Bien Pensant (13) Santosh Raj 58.5, 7. Amboseli (2) Surya Prakash 57.5, 8. Char Ek Char (9) Uday Kiran 57.5, 9. Mirzeta (6) Md. Ekram 57.5, 10. Deccan Ranger (11) Md. Ismail 55.5, 11. Iconic Star (8) Rafique Sk. 52.5, 12. Hopewell Island (10) G. Nareesh 51 and 13. Niloufer The Great (7) Arjun 50.

1. DECEMBER RAIN, 2. FORTUNE ART, 3. ICONIC STAR
Day's Best: CHAMPION REEF
Jackpot: 2, 3, 4, 5 & 6.
Mini Jackpot: 3, 4, 5 & 6.
Treble: (i) 1, 2 & 3, (ii) 4, 5 & 6. Tanala: All races.

Buddy speeds to victory in the Deccan Derby

HYDERABAD: The 30-to-1 rank outsider Buddy, ridden by Mukesh Kumar, pulled off a major upset by winning the Race2win Foundation Hyderabad Deccan Derby (Gr. I), the blue rib-and of the Hyderabad Monsoon Races staged here on Sunday (Oct. 4). The winner is owned by M/s. Subodh Kumar Ananthula & Prabhakar Chowdary Tripuraneni and trained by Magan Singh Parmar.

Mukesh took this ward of Dali-Dangal to the front soon after the start and dictated the pace throughout. Entering the home straight, Buddy continued to travel well and comfortably held off the late challenge from Moonveil and Mahogany to score a convincing victory. This win was memorable for trainer Magan Singh Parmar as it was his maiden success in the Deccan Derby.

1. DELHI RACE CLUB TROPHY (1,400m): BEAST MASTER (P. Sai Kumar) 1, Golden Aura (Sonu K) 2, Moonlite Rose (Surya Prakash) 3 and The Divinely (Rafique Sk.) 4. 5-1/2, 2 and 3. Im, 27.77s. ₹24 (w), 14, 11 and 14 (p). SHP: 45, THP: 40, FP: 133, Q: 63, Tanala: 777. Favourite: Beast Master. Owners: Mr. Mukund Kakani & Mr. S. Prasad Raju. Trainer: K.S.V. Prasad Raju.

2. BANGALORE TURF CLUB TROPHY (1,600m): RANI RUCKUS (G. Nareesh) 1, Sunny Day (Ashad Asbar) 2, Secret Option (Kuldeep Sr.) 3 and Only My Way (Sonu K) 4. 2-1/2, 4-3/4 and 2. Im, 41.12s. ₹20 (w), 11, 10 and 16 (p). SHP: 16, THP: 35, FP: 68, Q: 21, Tanala: 196. Favourite: Rani Ruckus.



Powering to glory: Mukesh Kumar piloting Buddy past the post ahead of Moonveil (Trevor up) and Mahogany (Vivek astride).

G. RAMAKRISHNA

Owner: Mr. Rakesh Reddy Kondakalla. Trainer: Robin R. Kondakalla.

3. TURF AUTHORITIES OF INDIA TROPHY (1,600m): PERCEPTION (Akshay Kumar) 1, Uchchaihshravas (Neeraj) 2, Star Of Night (Trevor) 3 and High Command (Ashad Asbar) 4. 1-1/2, Neck and 1-1/2. Im, 41.41s. ₹13 (w), 12 and 19 (p). SHP: 31, THP: 32, FP: 37, Q: 34, Tanala: 60. Favourite: Perception. Owner: Mr. Rakesh Reddy Kondakalla. Trainer: Robin R. Kondakalla.

4. MADRAS RACE CLUB TROPHY (1,800m): ONE NATION (P. Trevor) 1, Pristine Glory (Akshay K) 2, Pledge (Antony Raj) 3 and Bholi Punjab (Surya Prakash) 4. Neck, Neck and 9-1/4. Im, 53.64s. ₹40 (w), 12, 11 and 12 (p). SHP: 43,

THP: 44, FP: III, Q: 55, Tanala: 176. Favourite: Pledge. Owner: Col. Kuldeep Singh Garcha. Trainer: R.H. Sequeira.

5. ROYAL CALCUTTA TURF CLUB TROPHY (1,200m): AYUSHMAN (Afroz Khan) 1, Star Of Opera (Akshay K) 2, High Speed Dive (Ashad Asbar) 3 and State Man (Parmar) 4. Head, 1 and 3-1/2. Im, 12. 10s. ₹63 (w), 18, 11 and 11 (p). SHP: 35, THP: 41, FP: 154, Q: 68, Tanala: 976. Favourite: Star Of Opera. Owners: M/s. Dhruv Rajesh Sanghani, Mriza Ayub Baig & Avandira Kumar Dandamudi. Trainer: D. Netto.

6. WESTERN INDIA TURF CLUB TROPHY (1,100m): EK (Akshay Kumar) 1, Catchme If You Can (B. Nikhil) 2, Dubai Touch (Sonu K) 3 and Diligence (D.S. De-

ora) 4. 1, Head and Neck. Im, 7.02s. ₹27 (w), 11, 93 and 24 (p). SHP: 468, THP: 42, FP: 1,317, Q: 1,168, Tanala: 6,322. Favourite: Divine Tiger. wner: Mr. Syed Mohiuddin Mufeed. Trainer: Magan Singh.

7. RACE2WIN FOUNDATION HYDERABAD DECCAN DERBY (GR. I, 2,000m): BUDDY (DALI-DANGAL) (MUKESH KUMAR) 1, Moonveil (Sanus Par Aquam-Electra) (Trevor) 2, Mahogany (Phoenix Tower-Maisha) (Vivek G) 3 and Quattro (Lord Admiral-Coeur Rouge) (Ashad Asbar) 4. 2, Neck and 1. 2m, 04.96s. ₹371 (w), 122, 18 and 16 (p). SHP: 59, THP: 52, FP: 13,145, Q: 2,689, Tanala: 81,682. Favourite: Madante. Owners: M/s. Subodh Kumar Ananthula & Prabhakar Chowdary Tripuraneni. Trainer: Magan Singh.

8. MYSORE RACE CLUB TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,200m): DONTBLOCKMYWAY (Sonu Kumar) 1, Excalibur (Antony Raj) 2, Coming Home (B. Nikhil) 3 and Photograph (G. Nareesh) 4. Not run: Adalynn. 3/4, 4-1/4 and 7-3/4. Im, 14.19s. ₹34, 4-1/4 and 7-3/4. Im, 14.19s. ₹48 (w), 15,10 and 37 (p). SHP: 30, THP: 138, FP: 87, Q: 28, Tanala: 2,063. Favourite: Excalibur. Owner: Mr. Syed Mohiuddin Mufeed. Trainer: M.F. Ali Khan.

NOTE: Flare (Afroz K up) planted in the stalls and did not participate.
Jackpot: 70%: ₹14,44,535 (c/o) & 30%: 1,03,181 (6 tkts.).
Mini Jackpot: (i) 1,526 (222 tkts.), (ii) 1,74,827 (c/o).

Treble: (i) 80 (387 tkts.), (ii) 794 (114 tkts.), (iii) 15,735 (7 tkts.).

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The afterglow of the Asiad gold

For Shreyas, this was a much-needed victory. This campaign, away from probing eyes, would have facilitated his reintegration to progress further. The fact that he had most of his first-choice personnel around would have aided the process of refamiliarisation and put him in a good head-space

R. Kaushik

To be installed the overwhelming favourite ahead of any major sporting extravaganza is a double-edged sword. The moniker is suggestive of a formidable individual (or team) clearly more skilled, more temperamentally adjusted, and the most likely to go all the way, but it also comes with a rider. You are marked; the rest will be doubly determined to hunt you down and add a coveted scalp to their kitty.

Long before a single ball was bowled at the Asian Games, the Indian men's cricket team was fancied to come up trumps. The women too, of course, considering that they had just blazed to the Asia Cup in Dubai, sweeping everyone in front of them. Harmanpreet Kaur's intrepid bunch kept its tryst with gold in commanding fashion, brooking no opposition and flexing its not inconsiderable muscle with aplomb. Immediately thereafter, the spotlight turned to Shreyas Iyer and his lads, up against four other continental Test-playing nations who chose to put out experimental rather than full-strength outfits.

One of the talking points in the lead-up to the Asiad was why India's selectors had chosen to go with the tried and the tested. People harked back to the previous event in Hangzhou three years back, when Ruturaj Gaikwad led a second-string team to the gold medal after the final against Afghanistan was washed out, and wondered why a similar squad wasn't pieced together. For more than one reason, it is apparent.

The previous Asian Games overlapped with the 50-over World Cup hosted by India, thereby comprehensively ruling out the presence in China of the main squad. There is no gainsaying what personnel the selectors would have picked in the absence of the said overlap; that's delving into the realms of the hypothetical, which serves little purpose.

This time around too, India were involved in a three-match One-Day International series against West Indies at home; the first of the ODIs was played on September 27, a day before Shreyas' boys began their title defence in the quarterfinal against Afghanistan. While there are several players who are certainties in both white-ball formats internationally, India weren't too weakened by the absence from the 50-over set-up of Shreyas, the ODI vice-captain, and Ishan Kishan. Sure, they missed bowling spearheads Jasprit Bumrah and Axar Patel - Shubman Gill's unit conceded more than 1000 runs to the Caribbeans in the three fixtures - but what is the weight of an ODI series with little immediate import compared to an Asian Games gold medal?

Cricket authorities have worked tirelessly in ensuring the inclusion of the sport in multi-discipline events like the Asian Games and the Olympic Games. The International Cricket Council's avowed goal is to take the discipline to as many countries as possible. Having identified the 20-over format as the vehicle to drive that ambition, it has handed over memberships to a host of nations - the official T20I team rankings includes a staggering 102 countries - and conferred international status on matches involving even, say, Lesotho and Costa Rica, ranked 89th and joint-94th respectively.

Perfect sense

It therefore makes perfect sense to honour their presence in these big bashes by sending out the strongest team possible under the circumstances. Perhaps Shreyas might not say so publicly, but one is pretty certain that he would cherish an Asian Games gold medal more than being on the right side of a 2-1 scoreline against West Indies in a largely meaningless ODI series which, even with the World Cup a year away, was largely bereft of context. Batathons on flat tracks that took away the joy of a contest might have appealed to the spectators but it did little to edify the sport. But then, we digress.

Weight of favouritism

Shreyas and stand-in head coach V.V.S. Laxman were aware of the weight of favouritism imposed on the side. They also had the belief and the confidence that, never mind the relative strengths of their opponents, they would be unstoppable if they played at even 90% of their potential. Even at full strength, which Afghanistan were last month when they quixotically hosted India at Delhi's Arun Jaitley Stadium, the rest of the field would have been hard pressed to stretch India. Given that Shreyas had all the big guns at his disposal, from Abhishek Sharma and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi to



Cricket authorities have worked tirelessly in ensuring the inclusion of the sport in multi-discipline events like the Asian Games and the Olympic Games. The ICC's avowed goal is to take the discipline to as many countries as possible

Sanju Samson and Kishan, and Bumrah and Axar, India had to play extraordinarily poorly and their opponents, whoever they might have been, had to play out of their skins to orchestrate an upset.

Banana skin

As their one-off T20I against Japan showcased last month, an abridged T20 game can be a banana skin. On a pitch that served as a horrible advertisement for a 5-overs-a-side affair, India huffed and puffed to a two-run victory. More than any other format, the 20-over slugfest narrows the gap between teams, and when that is reduced by 75%, the chances of a more level playing field increase exponentially.

Most pitches at the Asian Games weren't up to scratch, favouring the bowling sides to a massive degree - how the Indian and West Indian 50-over exponents would have loved that - even though the final was played on a pretty good surface that produced more 400 runs. India's overwhelming superiority was never more evident than in the semifinal against Sri Lanka when Kishan's unbeaten 80 was nearly twice as much as what the entire opposition managed. India played with flair and imagination, and without the burden of expectations and fear. A lot of credit for that should go to Laxman, as good a man-manager as any the country has been blessed with but temporarily - one hopes - lost to the coaching spectrum because of personal reasons.

Laxman has now shepherd India to successive Asian Games gold medals, even though he might not individually have anything to show for it. Were he the sort, he would clamber on to the tallest rooftop and tom-tom about his contributions. But he didn't do that when he was winning matches and shaping miracles for the country, so he is not going to embark on that journey now. In

India, some people are more equal than others and that will never change, which is why Laxman's contributions will inevitably fly under the radar though as a batter, few have influenced the outcomes of Test matches more than the stylist from Hyderabad.

One of the prime tenets of Laxman's coaching philosophy is constancy and stability. Among the others is communication. During his playing career, Laxman suffered on both counts, so he is in a far better position to appreciate the significance of role clarity, of being made to feel wanted, and of being kept in the loop about developments so that no one is operating in a vacuum. Many of the players who travelled with him to Zimbabwe in July, immediately after the misadventures in Ireland and England, and to the Asian Games, have spoken in private of the positive influence of the 51-year-old and how his openness, approachability and his sense of balance and fairness have impacted them. Laxman is a firm believer in processes, but also in not rigidly sticking to them or making decisions on the fly, on a whim and a fancy. While no coach can ever be accused of winning or losing matches, it is undeniable that the environment they fashion within the changing room plays a massive part in how the wards approach the game. On that count, Laxman has few equals.

Lifting morale

For Shreyas, this was a much-needed victory. Brought back to the T20I fold after two and a half years and installed as the captain with India deciding to move on from Suryakumar Yadav - World Cup-winning skipper but short on runs - he must have felt the heat after surrendering 0-2 to Ireland and 0-4 to England in his first two assignments. The clean sweep against Afghanistan last month must have lifted his morale, but this campaign, away from probing eyes, would have facilitated his reintegration to progress further. The fact that he had most of his first-choice personnel around would have aided the process of refamiliarisation and put him in a good headspace, imperative because he is the designated ODI vice-captain and will be expected to play a big part with the bat at No. 4 in the lead-up to and during the World Cup.

Shreyas knows he has a great bunch to

work with. He will have taken particular joy in the sustained good form of Kishan, for whom 2026 has heralded a breathtaking second coming, and the continued development as a batter, an individual and leader of Tilak Varma, his T20I deputy. Like he had in the Asia Cup final in Dubai in September last year when he steered India past Pakistan in a tense run-chase, the left-hander from Hyderabad upped his game against the old foe in the title clash on Saturday, his unbeaten 51, off just 22 deliveries, pushing the total past 200 and out of reach of a spirited Pakistan well served by the exciting Hasan Nawaz.

Tilak was batting at No. 6, somewhat below his normal and preferred position because India stacked up their batting even if it meant they were a bowler light. He walked in with just 41 deliveries left in the innings and made a spectacular impact, showing how far he has come in international cricket. Just 23 months back, in South Africa towards the end of 2024, he sought to occupy the No. 3 position that Suryakumar had made his own. When the skipper acquiesced, Tilak expressed his thanks with two hundreds in three nights, in Centurion and adjacent Johannesburg respectively. Now, he doesn't need the No. 3 position, which puts him in a position to play more balls than anyone else but the two openers, to unfurl his repertoire and shape the destination of 20-over games, which is exactly the kind of graph one would expect of a 23-year-old who is desperate to be a permanent for the country across formats.

Already, the Asian Games adventure is a thing of the past, what with the five-match T20I series against West Indies due to begin in Lucknow on Tuesday. A vast chunk of those who travelled to Japan will line up in the administrative and legislative capital of Uttar Pradesh, as a new challenge beckons. West Indies have shown in the ODIs that they are no pushovers and India will have their work cut out. And while they know that it doesn't guarantee victory, Shreyas and his boys will still bask in the afterglow of an Asian Games gold medal. Whyever not?

THE GIST

Shreyas and stand-in head coach Laxman had the belief and the confidence that, never mind the relative strengths of their opponents, they would be unstoppable if they played at even 90% of their potential

One of the prime tenets of Laxman's coaching philosophy is constancy and stability. Among the others is communication. Many of the players who travelled with him to Zimbabwe in July, immediately after the misadventures in Ireland and England, and to the Asian Games, have spoken in private of the positive influence of the 51-year-old

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Letting the wind flow freely is the secret to cooling our cities

Slower winds can affect how people experience heat; normally, the air immediately above the ground becomes saturated with water vapour due to evaporation; when winds blow faster, the saturated air is replaced with drier air; slower winds, however, also limit evaporation

Sambavi Parthasarathy
CHENNAI

India’s cities are seeing buildings getting taller and populations becoming more dense. The hotter days in many of these cities also come with high humidity, and can make the experience of heat seem unforgiving. One of the reasons is often a perceived lack of winds, which often have to make their way through the nooks and crannies of crowded streets before reaching a window.

Slower winds can affect how people experience heat. Normally, the air immediately above the ground becomes saturated with water vapour due to evaporation. When winds blow faster, the saturated air is replaced with drier air. Slower winds, however, also limit evaporation.

Wind speed near the ground has been dropping worldwide, in a phenomenon called terrestrial stilling, since the 1980s.

Disrupted flow

“Multiple factors lead to reduced wind speed specifically in the near surface level,” according to Amruthraj M.N., a consultant with the Sustainable Energy Lab at the Indian Institute for Human Settlements (IIHS), Bengaluru.

“When we say surface level, it’s typically around 10 m from the floor, where a lot of pedestrians move around the city and that’s the place where typically there’s reduced wind speed that has been seen over a few decades.”

Aaron Serre, a meteorologist and recent graduate in atmospheric science from the University of Alabama in Huntsville, U.S., said dense urban infrastructure and high-rise buildings tend to disrupt wind flow, create turbulence, and increase surface friction, resulting in slower winds near the surface.

He also said the loss of vegetation and the introduction of asphalt and concrete instead drastically reduce evapotranspiration, intensifying the urban heat island effect.

“Urbanisation and buildings ... taking into account the analysis of wind speeds across these cities, can be built to ensure that there is wind flow at that level,” Mr. Amruthraj noted. “Unfortunately, not a lot of people follow that approach.”

He added that many structures like higher compound walls and podiums restrict wind flow in previously defined wind corridors.

Downdraught effect

India’s metropolitan cities are replete with high compound walls, podiums, and high-rise buildings of varying heights, often clumped together without adequate spacing, affecting the wind’s speed –



A view of the South Mumbai skyline in 2024. When winds slam into high-rise buildings, they can be forced downwards along the structures in a phenomenon called the downdraught effect. DRONE MASTER/UNSPLASH

rougher surfaces have a greater slowing effect – and direction.

When a wind’s flow is interrupted by tall buildings, it can instead be funnelled through narrow spaces, where it accelerates and builds up into a gust before reaching the pedestrians walking around the buildings. This phenomenon is called the Venturi effect and has been observed in London and Jaipur, among other cities.

As well, when winds slam into high-rise buildings, they can be forced downwards along the structures in a phenomenon called the downdraught effect, which further pushes the wind lower down into stronger gusts.

However, Prasad Vaidya, a senior adviser at IIHS and lead of its Sustainable Energy Lab, said that while there have been studies showing stilling is underway, there are no specific studies that compare rural versus urban stilling to reveal the impact of urbanisation.

He also said wind speeds are changing even as cities are warming, losing trees, and losing water bodies – and it has been hard to establish causal relationships between them.

‘Wind record’

Depending on their geometry, other physical characteristics, and their environs, tall buildings can also create pockets sheltered from winds along the streets surrounding them. If the people there are also experiencing an urban heat island, the lack of wind may distress them

further. “While there are no specific studies that correlate it,” Mr. Vaidya said, “there is enough experience to show that higher building forms that are unplanned will contribute to [lower] wind speeds and additional heat stress.”

“We need to build a homogenised wind record firstly because, right now, the placement of an anemometer may be inconsistent,” Yugank Goyal, associate professor and chair at the J.S.W. School of Public Policy at IIM Ahmedabad, said. (An anemometer is a device to measure wind speed.)

Slower winds can also take more time to disperse air pollution. “We have done some [computational fluid dynamics] simulations. What we found is that maintaining good air movement through a breezeway or corridor is not easy, because small changes in building shape ... can actually cause eddies and swirls and reduce the wind speed through the length of the breezeway,” Mr. Vaidya said.

Computational fluid dynamics is a computer-based modelling technique to help simulate and analyse the behaviour of fluids in different conditions.

In other words, “the reality is that cities are so complex that little movements – somebody putting out a window or canopies – are going to affect the wind’s movement.”

‘City ventilation maps’

Mr. Amruthraj said that while research is ongoing on how wind flows through cities, computational fluid dynamics

modelling of how buildings’ shapes, wind corridors, open spaces, and other features affect wind speeds is not routinely incorporated into urban design and planning.

One reason is computational fluid dynamics is expensive to implement. The computer simulation models and tracks motions within a turbulent fluid going from small to large, from fleeting to long-lived. To resolve them all, the simulation needs increasingly fine spatial grids and correspondingly shorter time-steps. As a result, the total computational cost of resolving a turbulent flow scales roughly as the cube of the Reynolds number, a number measuring the amount of turbulence.

Mr. Vaidya cited assessments by the governments of Stuttgart, Seoul, and Hong Kong to improve city-wide ventilation, and said, “Cities like Chennai and Mumbai can actually do something similar, but we haven’t seen specific wind-related studies tied to heat and pollution happening in India, as much as we would like to see them.”

According to him, “part of the reason is that these studies require [fluid dynamics] simulations, which are extremely computer-intensive and require expertise.” “We need to use satellite imagery to evaluate each city’s changing form,” Dr. Goyal added. “We could potentially create city ventilation maps and connect all this to master plans.”

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THE GIST

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India’s metropolitan cities are replete with high compound walls, podiums, and high-rise buildings of varying heights, often clumped together without adequate spacing, affecting the wind’s speed – rougher surfaces have a greater slowing effect – and direction

When a wind’s flow is interrupted by tall buildings, it can instead be funnelled through narrow spaces, where it accelerates and builds up into a gust before reaching the pedestrians walking around the buildings

This phenomenon is called the Venturi effect and has been observed in London and Jaipur, among other cities

BIG SHOT



People watch a shark nicknamed ‘Bukangi’ swimming in a canal at the North Port in Busan, South Korea, on Friday. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Tuvalu: Barely above water

Agence France-Presse

When leaders visit the coral atolls that form the Pacific nation of Tuvalu on October 5, they will find a once-vibrant ecosystem wiped out due to climate change. The pre-COP gathering, hosted by Fiji ahead of the annual UN climate conference in Turkey, has been billed as the Pacific’s chance to show the world first-hand the damage wrought by climate change in the vast ocean region.

Leaders are also set to spend a day on low-lying Tuvalu, an atoll over 800 km north of Fiji. Here, scientists say, a marine heatwave in 2024 wiped out an estimated 99.9% of the coral that built the Tuvalu islands.

“The very system that created the islands has died. It wasn’t pollution. It wasn’t overfishing. Just a direct result from climate change,” marine biologist Austin Bowden-Kerby, who visited last year and documented the devastation, said.

Thanks to rising sea levels, scientists fear the entire archipelago could be unliveable by the end of the century.

Local scientist Rajneel Singh said climate change has already affected the waters that have long sustained Tuvalu’s population of 10,600. “Elders used to fish for red snappers and other things,” he said. “It’s no longer frequent in the catch. And the size of the fish has been reduced as well.”

Scientists presented their findings to



Pacific Ocean waves hit the coast of Funafuti Atoll in Tuvalu on February 19, 2004. When leaders visit the coral atolls that form the Pacific nation of Tuvalu next week, they will find a once-vibrant ecosystem wiped out by climate change. AFP

Tuvalu’s fisheries minister in December last year and were met with disbelief. “They didn’t know,” Singh said of the meeting. “It was very difficult for him, to realise, to see photos and to listen about the situation.”

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’